Diversity and Global Policy: Dimensions of Inequality

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Recap of the Last Lecture

We care about diversity because significant, observed inequalities exist between groups in society.

The egalitarian perspective emphasizes the importance of personal responsibility in determining acceptable levels of inequality.

According to Sen, public policies should maximize people's freedom to decide and become who they want to be.

According to Roemer, public policies should attempt to reward merit and correct for luck in realized outcomes.

Roadmap for Today

But before designing policies, we need to quantify inequalities [Block 1].

Today, we will cover several essential dimensions of inequality from a global and historical perspective.

This is hard for several reasons:

- Limited data availability in many countries and for the past
- Strong research focus on developed countries – in particular the United States – at the expense of developing countries

We will mainly focus on men-women differences, as it is a relatively universal divide.

The Global Gender Gap Index

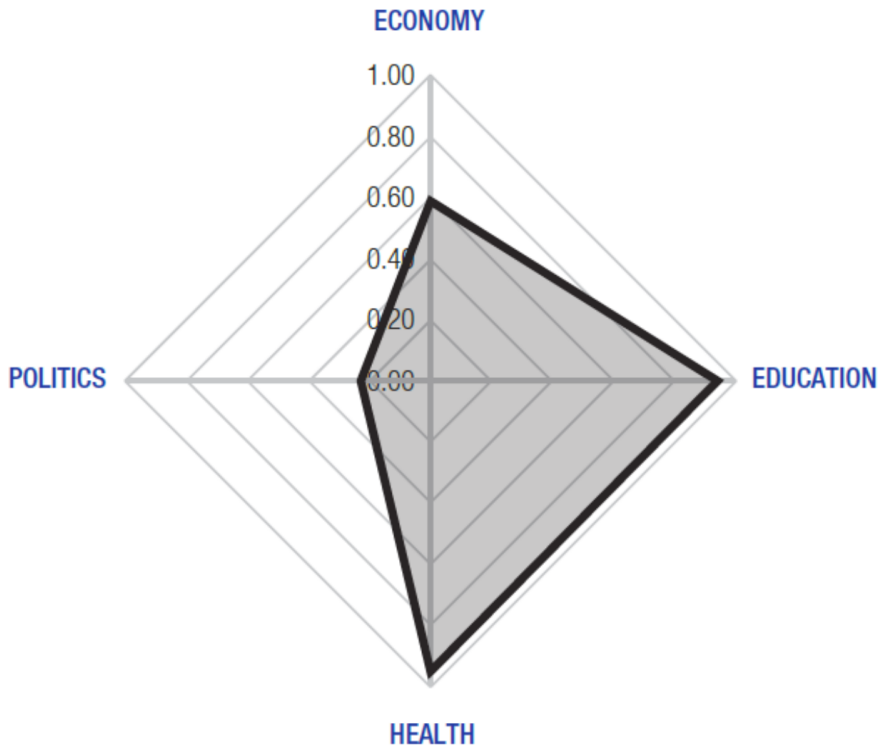
The Global Gender Gap Index monitors gender inequality (WEF, 2022).

It measures gender gaps along four core dimensions:

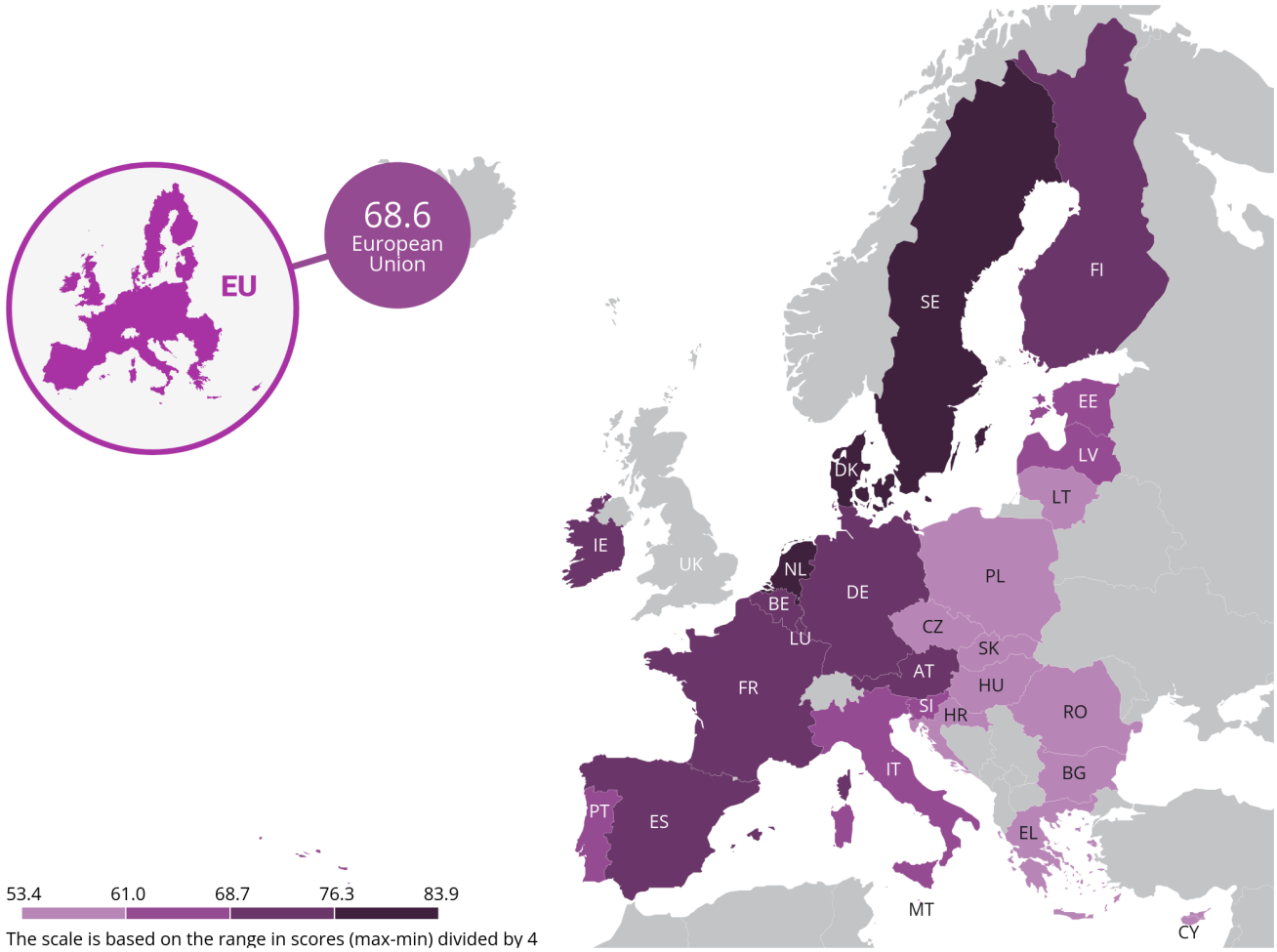
- Economic opportunities
- Education
- Political empowerment
- Health and survival

We will later add "cultural values and stereotypes" to this list. Though they are often harder to measure precisely, they are also essential to understand the other gaps.

Average Global Performance



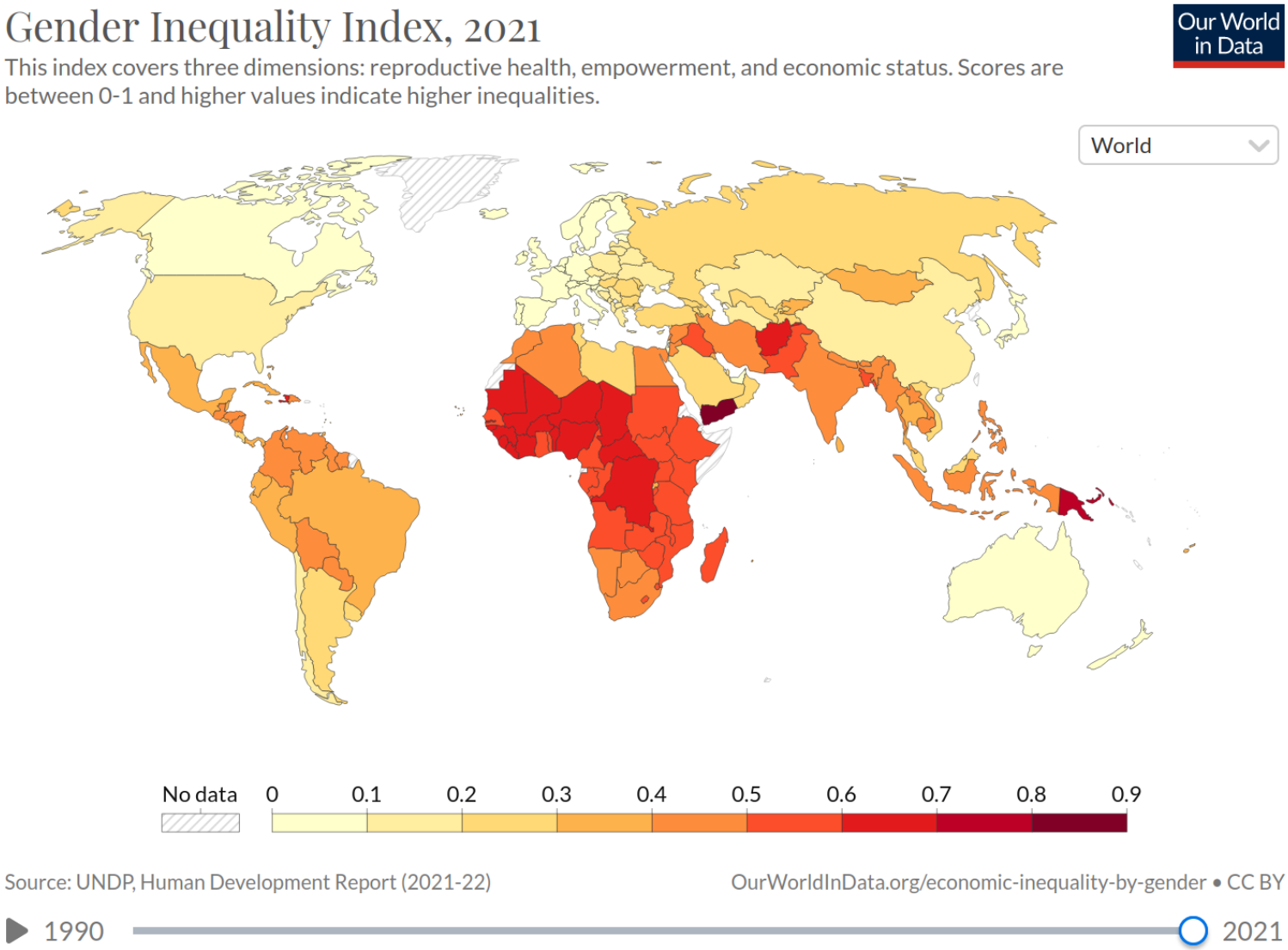
The world has nearly closed the gap in health and education, but economic opportunities and political empowerment still lag behind.



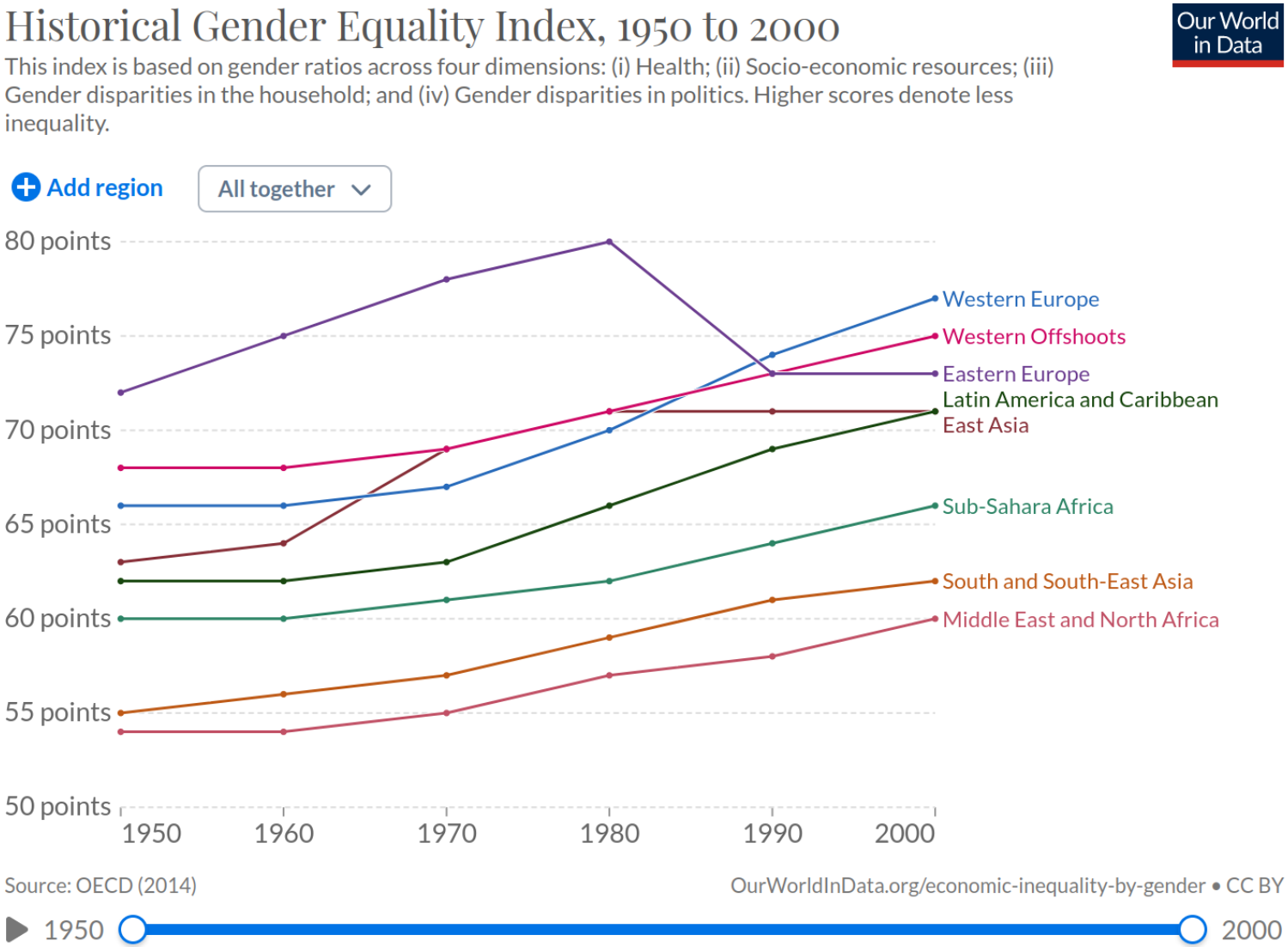
This average performance masks considerable heterogeneity.

Europe

Country	Rank		Score
	Regional	Global	
Iceland	1	1	0.908
Finland	2	2	0.860
Norway	3	3	0.845
Sweden	4	5	0.822
Ireland	5	9	0.804
Germany	6	10	0.801
Lithuania	7	11	0.799
Switzerland	8	13	0.795
Belgium	9	14	0.793
France	10	15	0.791
Spain	11	17	0.788
Albania	12	18	0.787
Austria	13	21	0.781
United Kingdom	14	22	0.780
Serbia	15	23	0.779
Latvia	16	26	0.771
Netherlands	17	28	0.767
Portugal	18	29	0.766
Denmark	19	32	0.764
Slovenia	20	39	0.744
Bulgaria	21	42	0.740
Luxembourg	22	46	0.736
Estonia	23	52	0.733
Montenegro	24	54	0.732
Italy	25	63	0.720
Slovak Republic	26	67	0.717
North Macedonia	27	69	0.716
Bosnia and Herzegovina	28	73	0.710
Czech Republic	29	76	0.710
Poland	30	77	0.709
Malta	31	85	0.703
Hungary	32	88	0.699
Romania	33	90	0.698
Cyprus	34	93	0.696
Greece	35	100	0.689

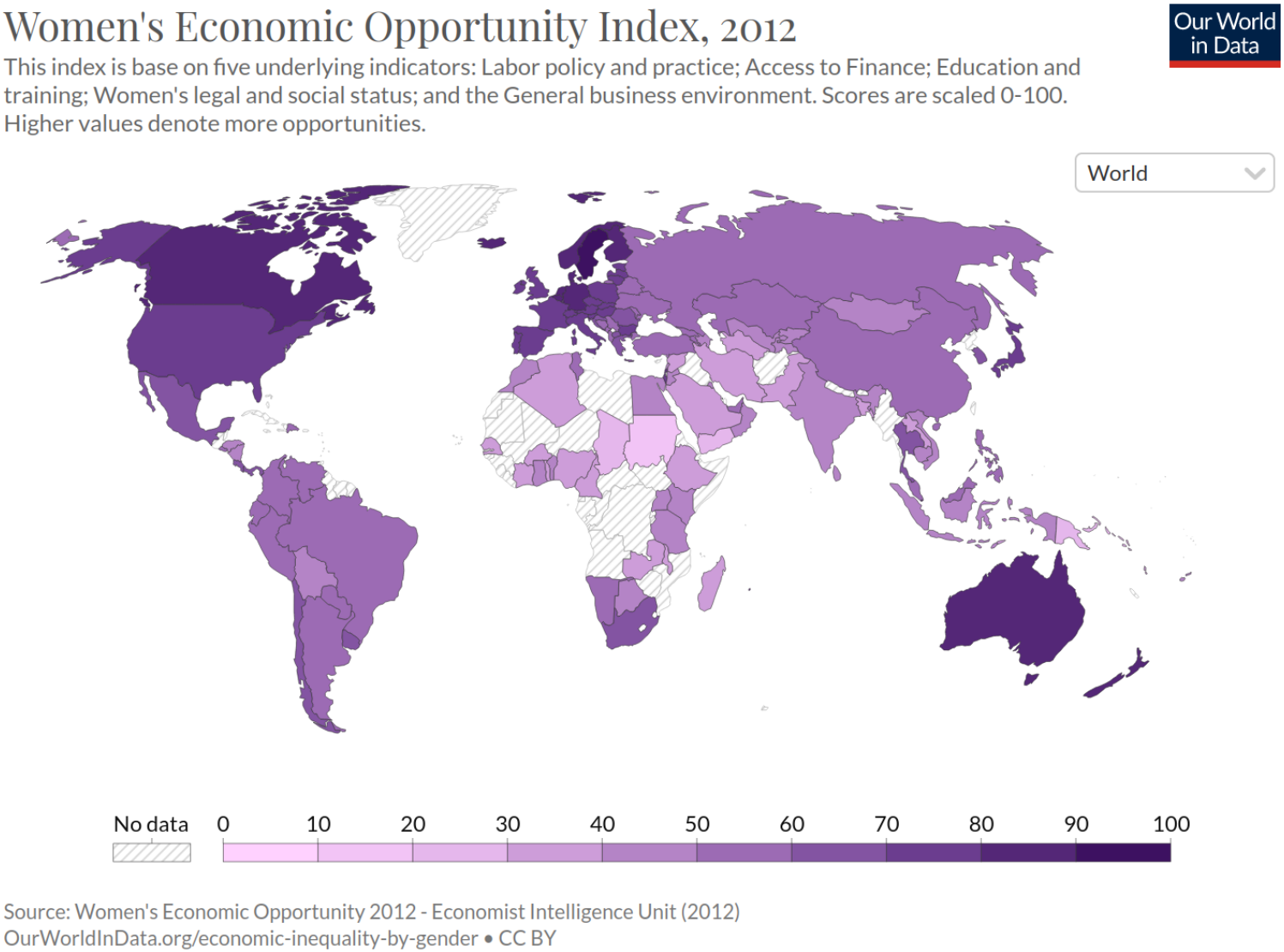


Other indices corroborate these findings (Ortiz-Ospina and Roser, 2018).

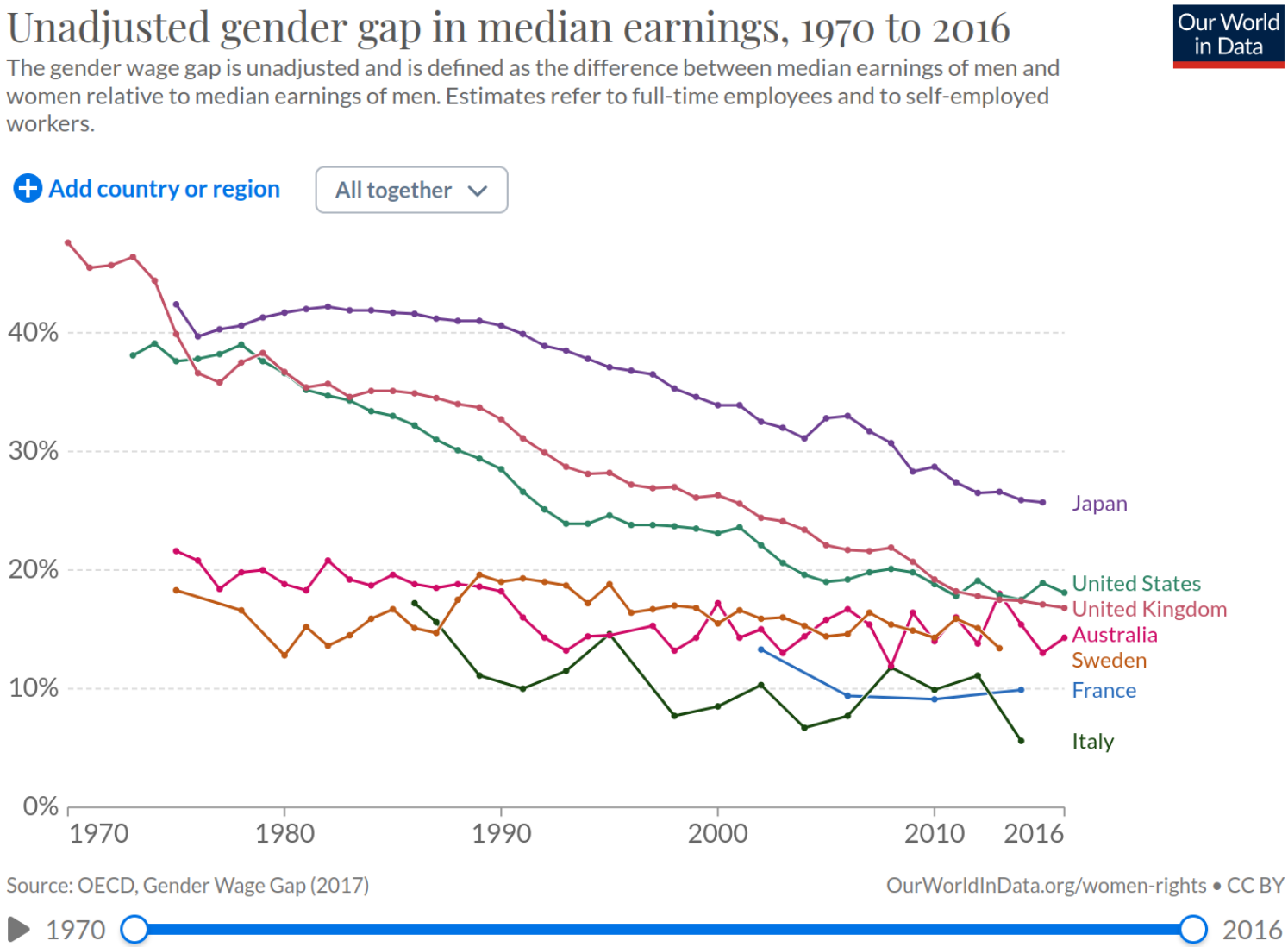


But there is a general trend towards improvement.

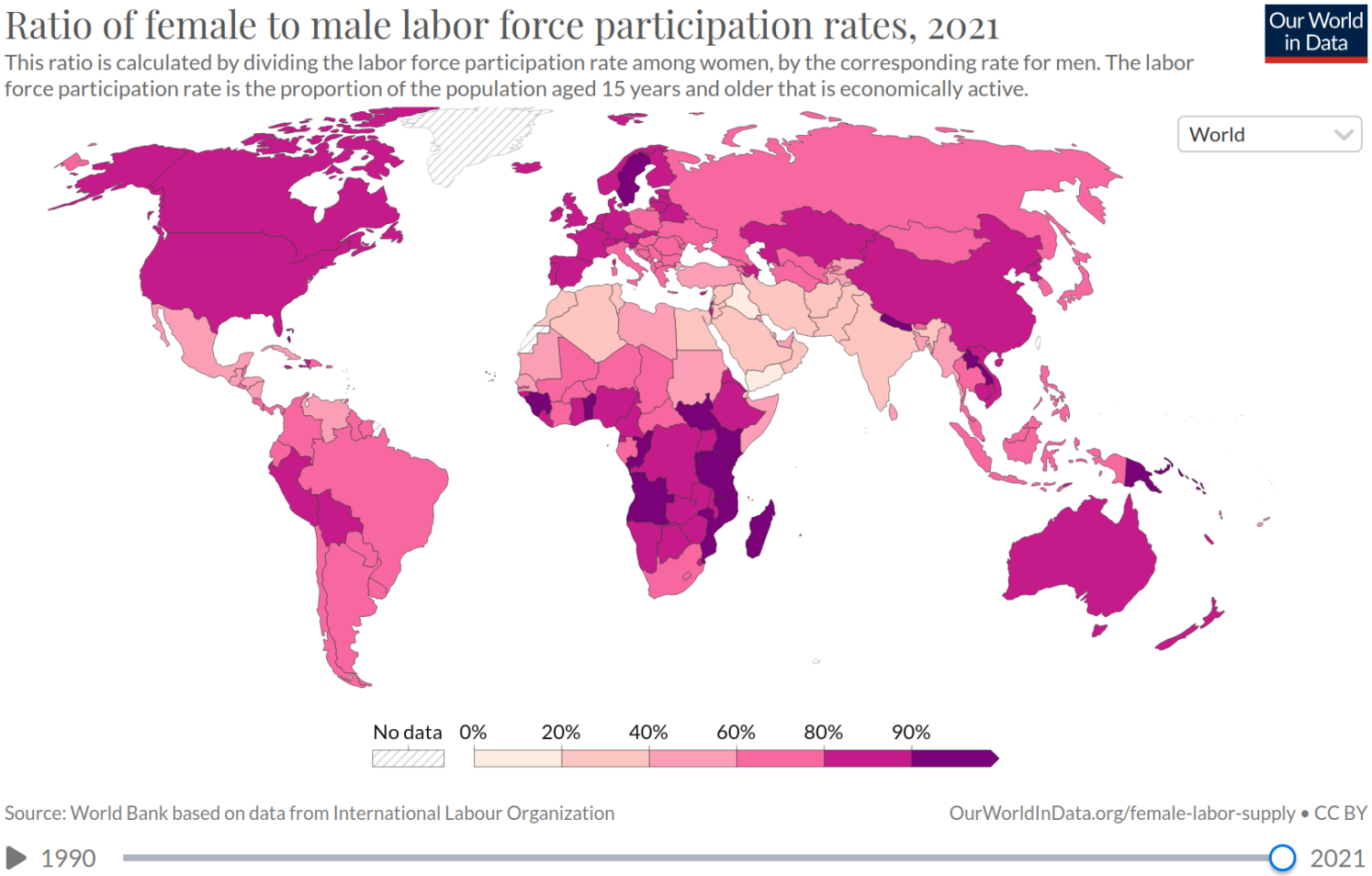
Let's look at each dimension separately...



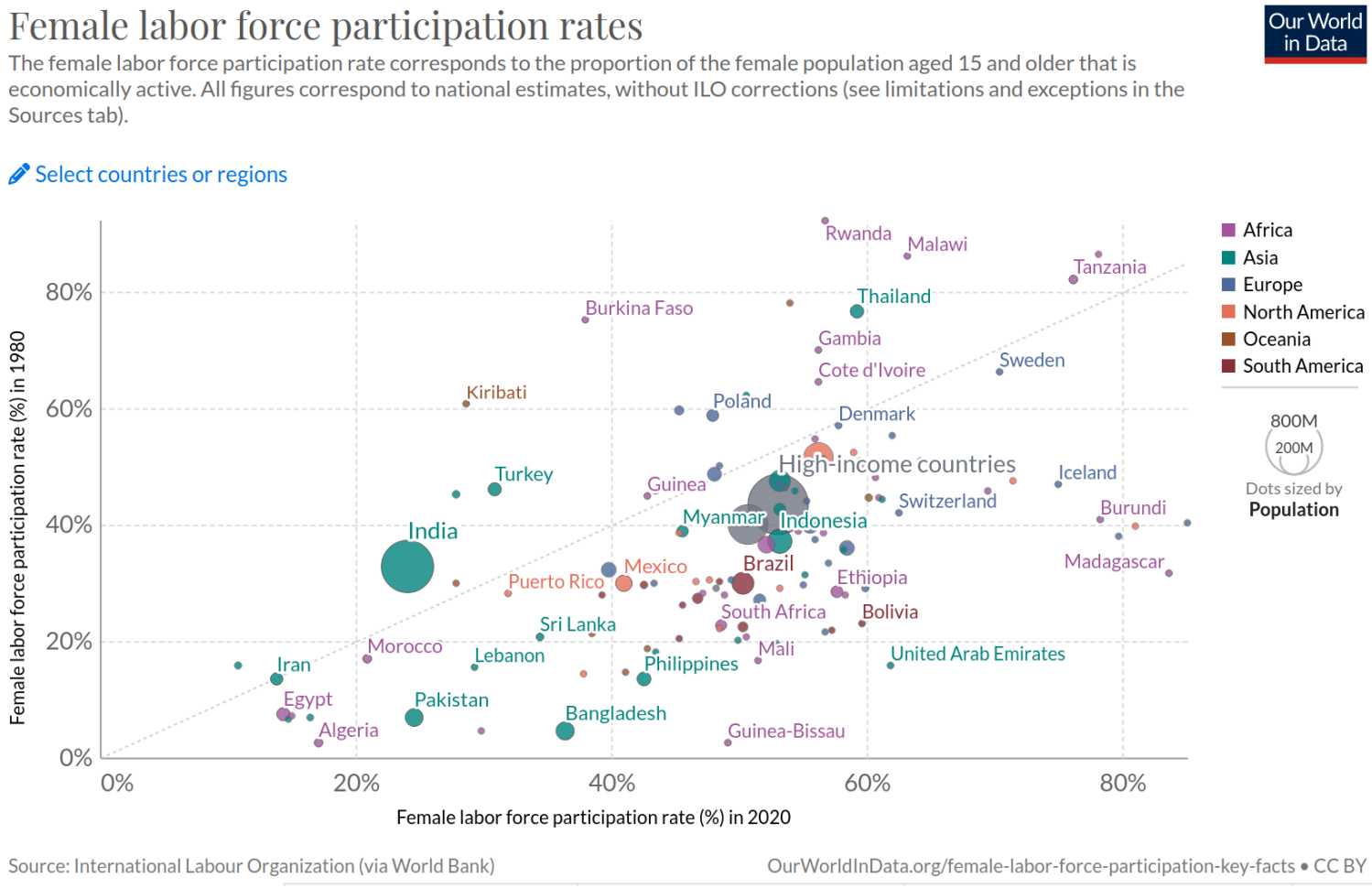
In general, women are at a disadvantage for economic opportunities.



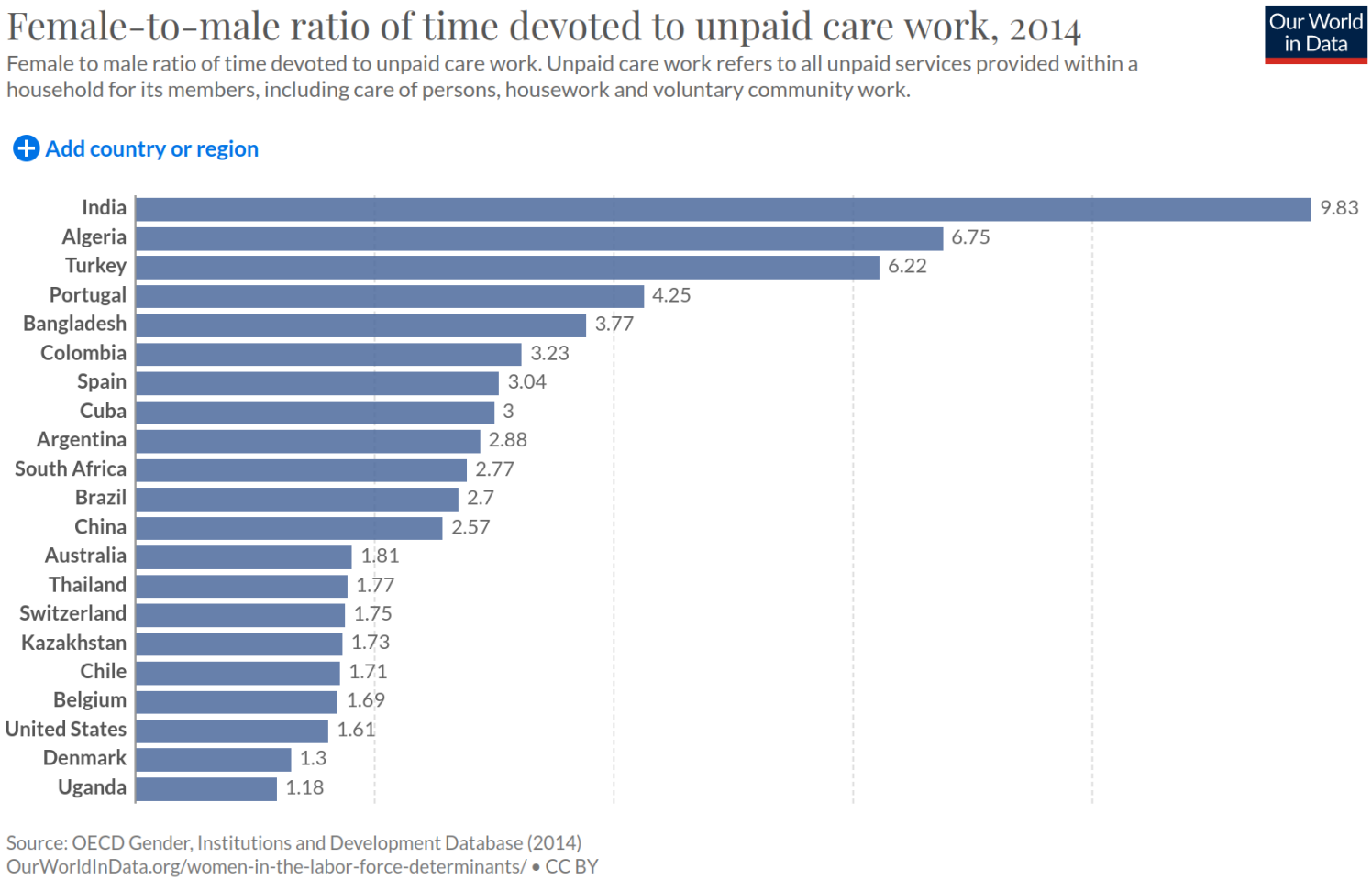
The gender wage gap is decreasing but persistent.



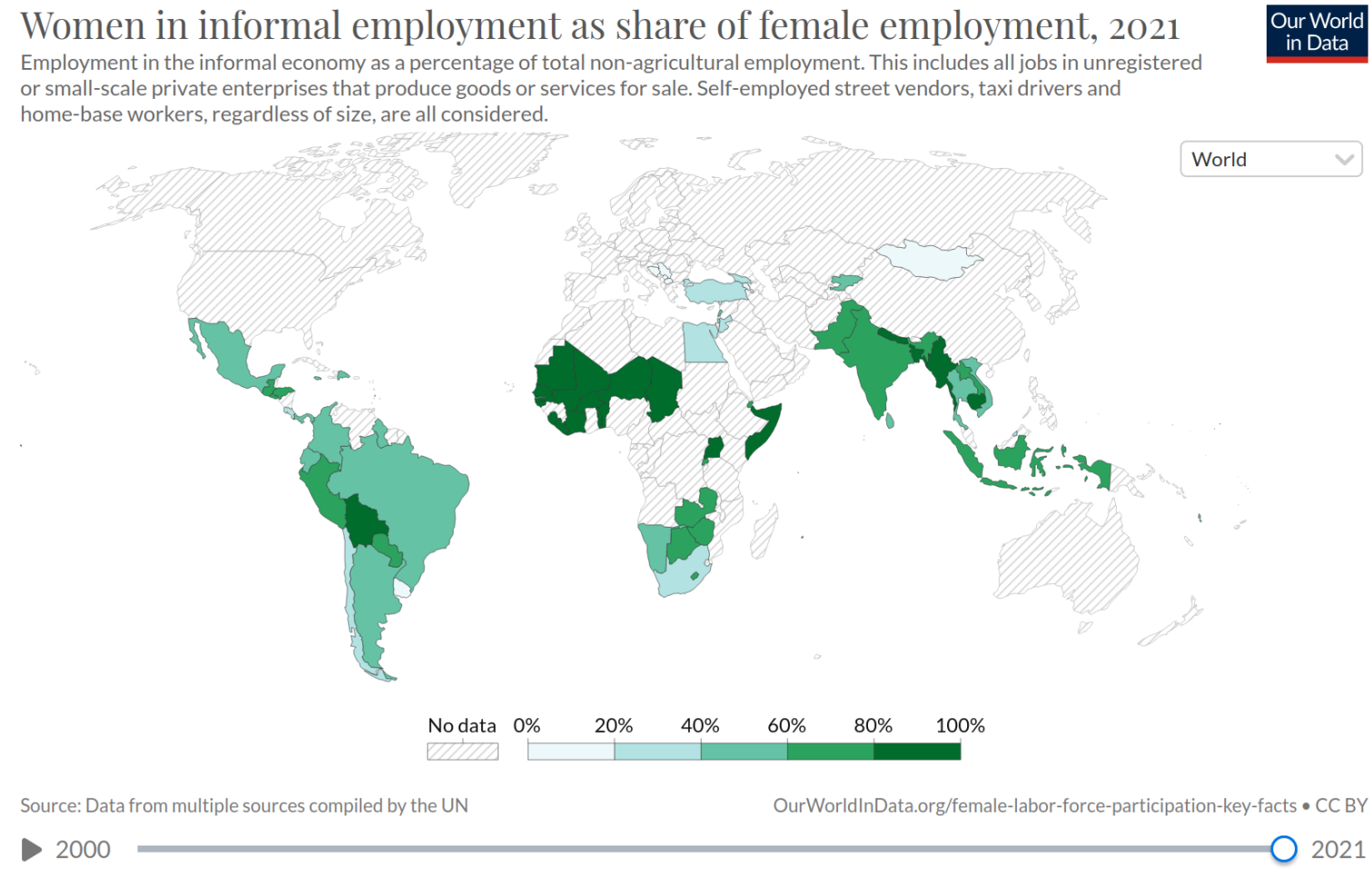
Women are also less likely to participate in the labor market.



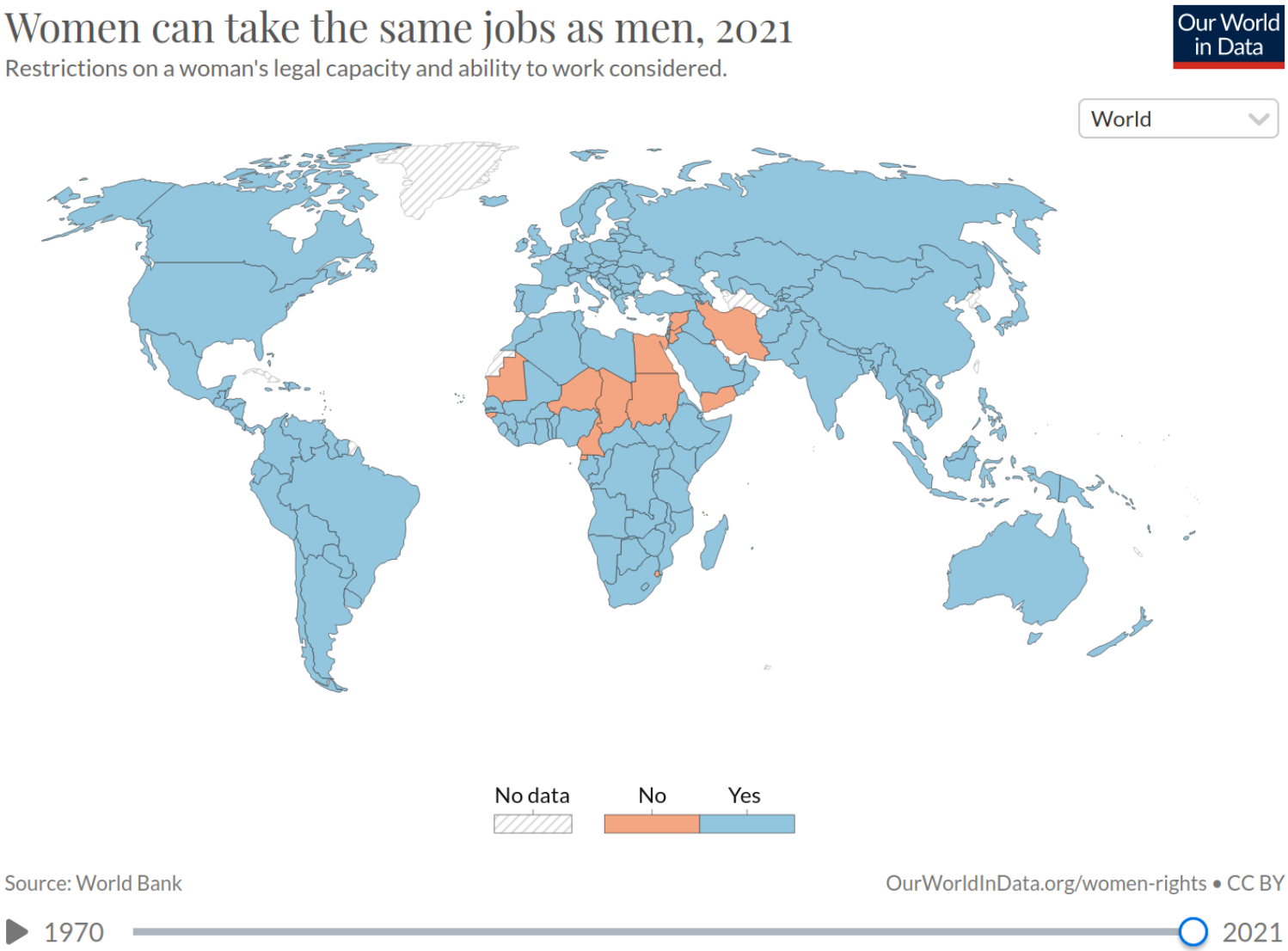
But the situation is also improving.



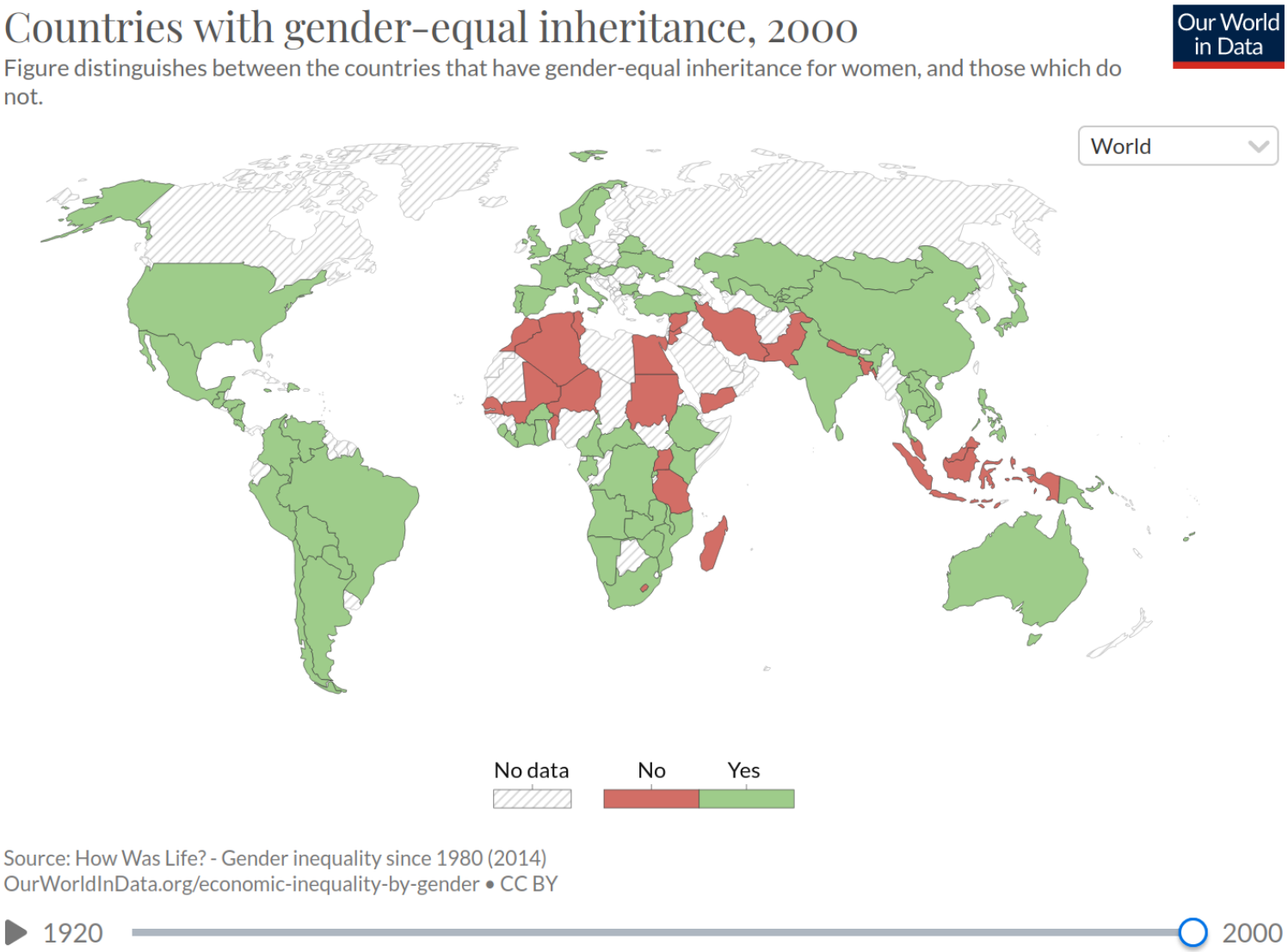
Part of the problem is the unequal burden of unpaid care work.



In practice, many women actually work, but informally.



In some countries, this is partly the result of legal constraints.



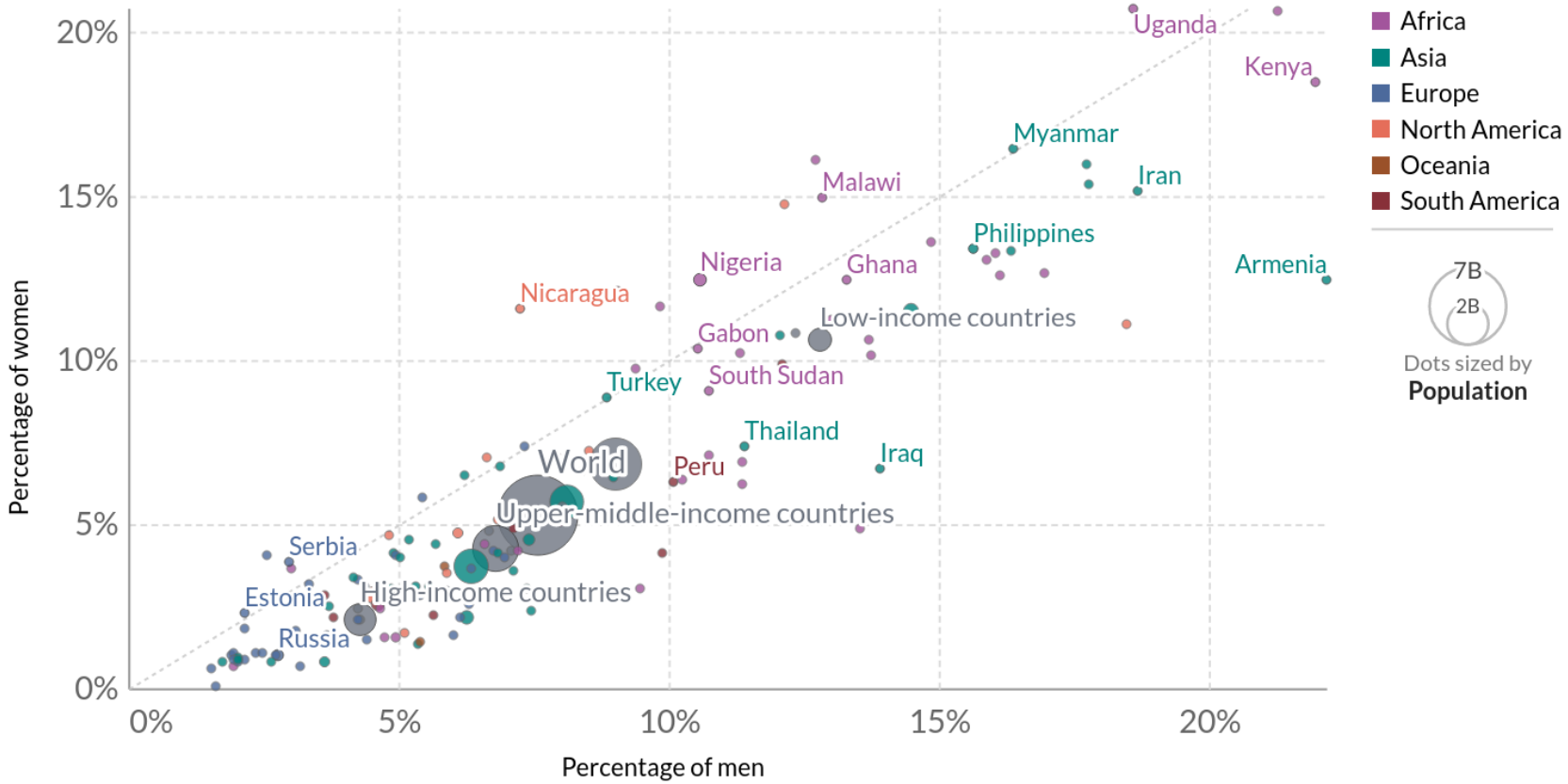
The problem extends beyond earnings to wealth acquisition.

Borrowing to start or expand business, men vs. women, 2017

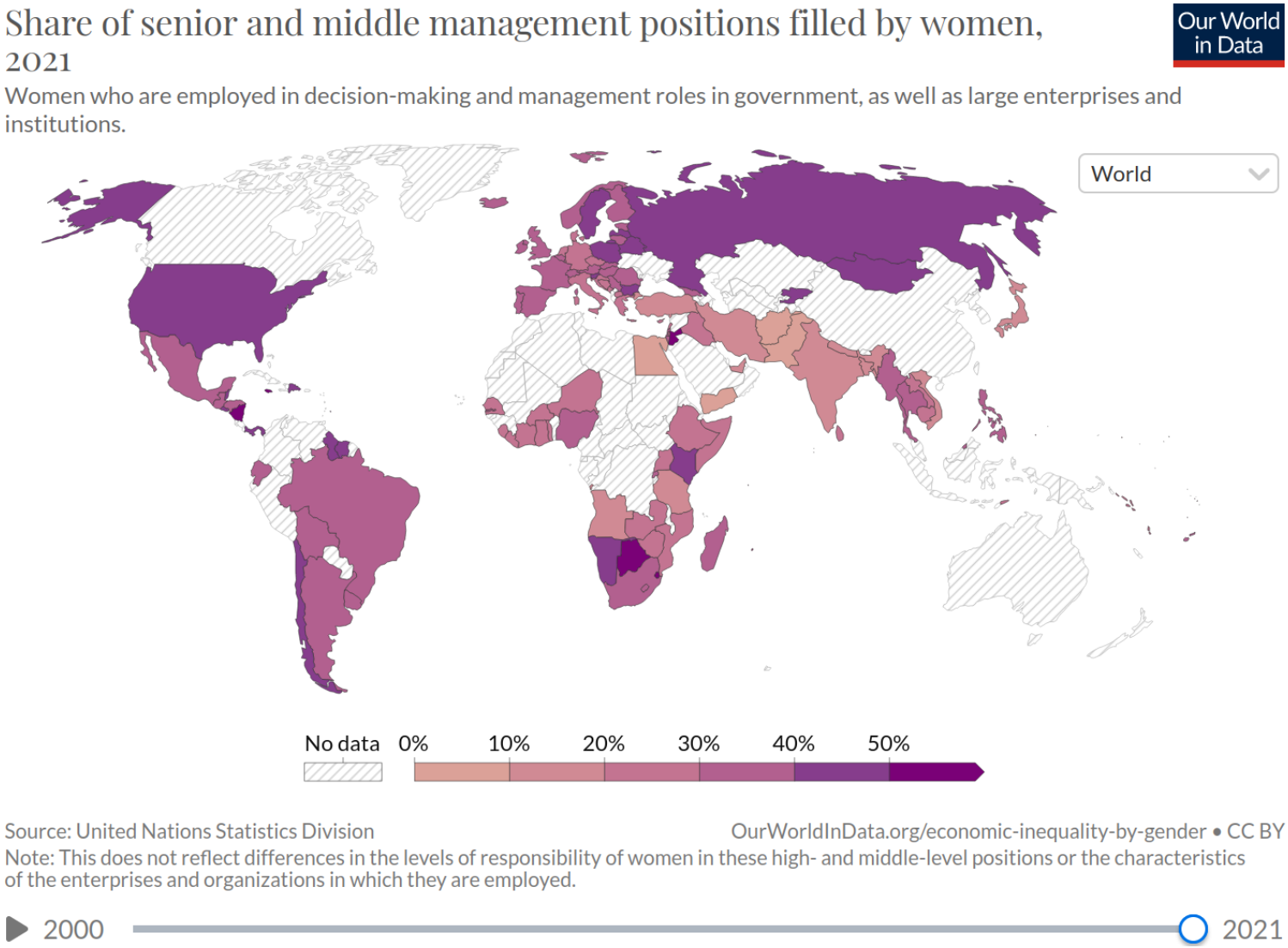
Percentage of men and women (ages 15+) who report borrowing any money in the past 12 months (by themselves or together with someone else) to start, operate, or expand a farm or business. Colors represent world regions. Bubble sizes are proportional to the population of the country.

Our World in Data

Select countries or regions



Source: World Bank, Gender Statistics (based on multiple sources)
OurWorldInData.org/economic-inequality-by-gender • CC BY



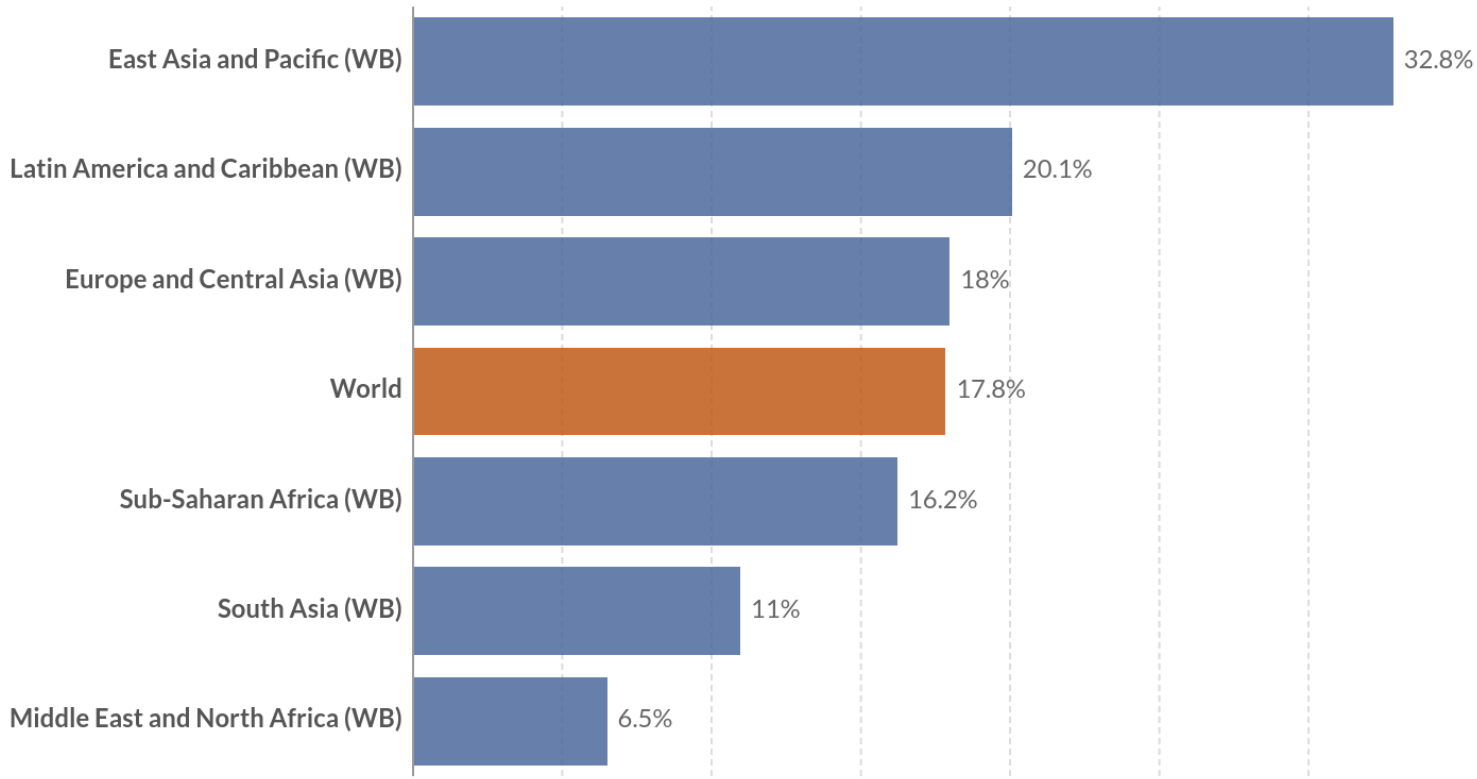
Among working women, top management positions are rare, suggesting a "glass ceiling".

Share of firms with a female top manager, 2020

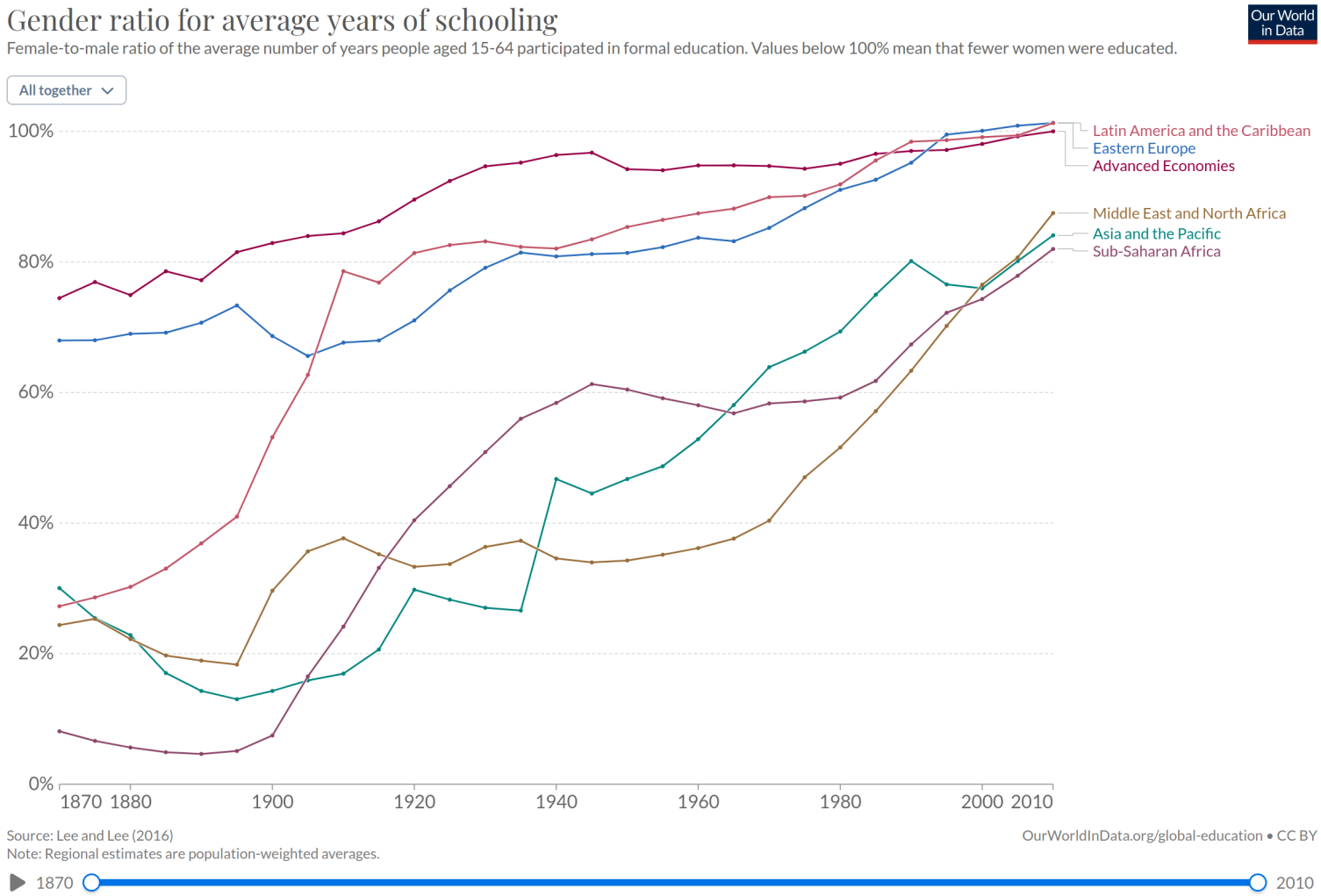
Top manager refers to the highest ranking manager or CEO of the establishment. This may be the owner if she works as the manager of the firm.

Our World in Data

Add country or region



Source: World Bank, Gender Statistics (based on multiple sources)
OurWorldInData.org/economic-inequality-by-gender • CC BY



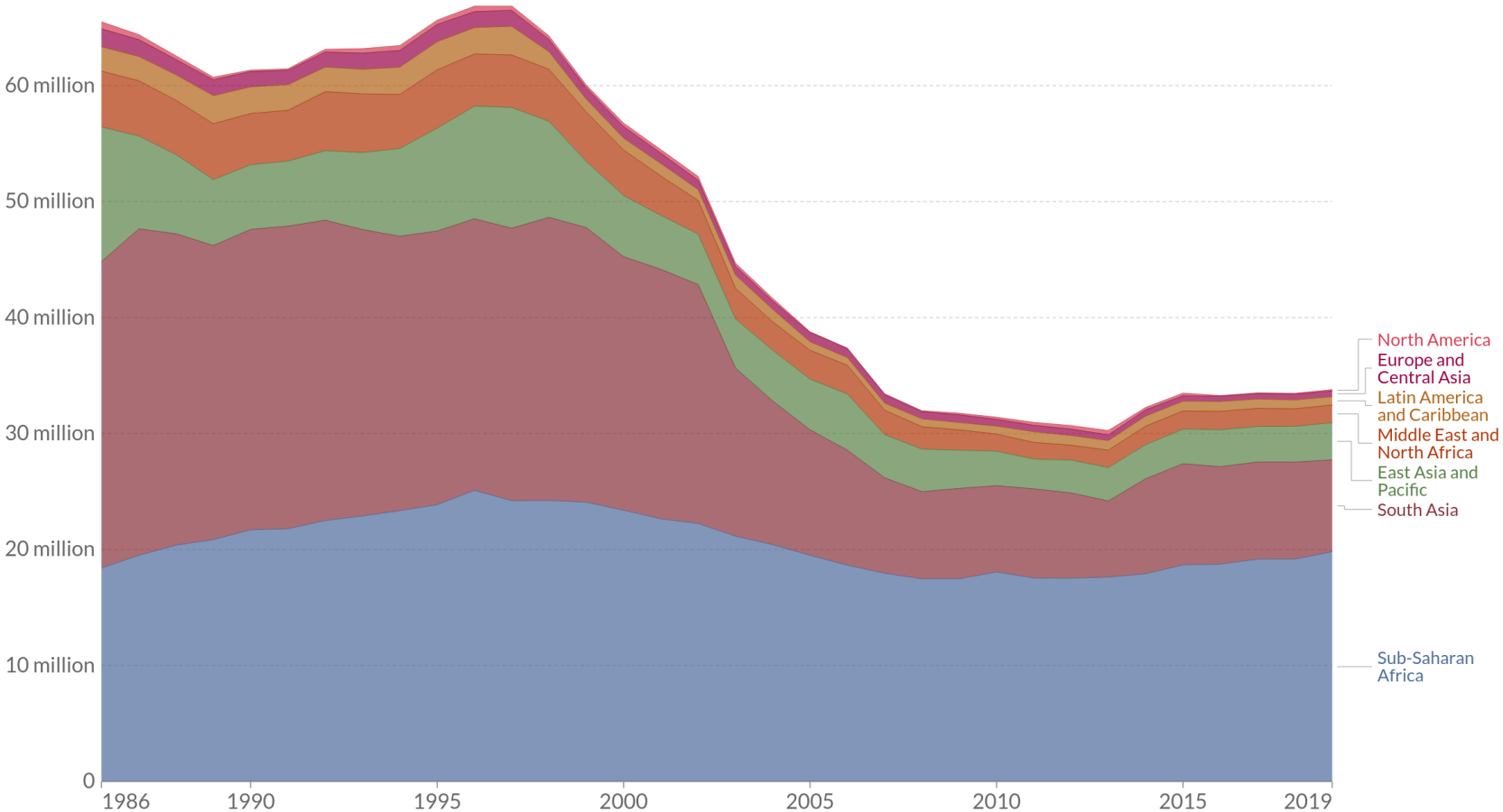
The world has drastically decreased the educational attainment gap.

Girls of primary school age who are out-of-school, by world region, 1986 to 2019

Children in the official primary school age range who are not enrolled in either primary or secondary schools.

Our World in Data

All together | Relative

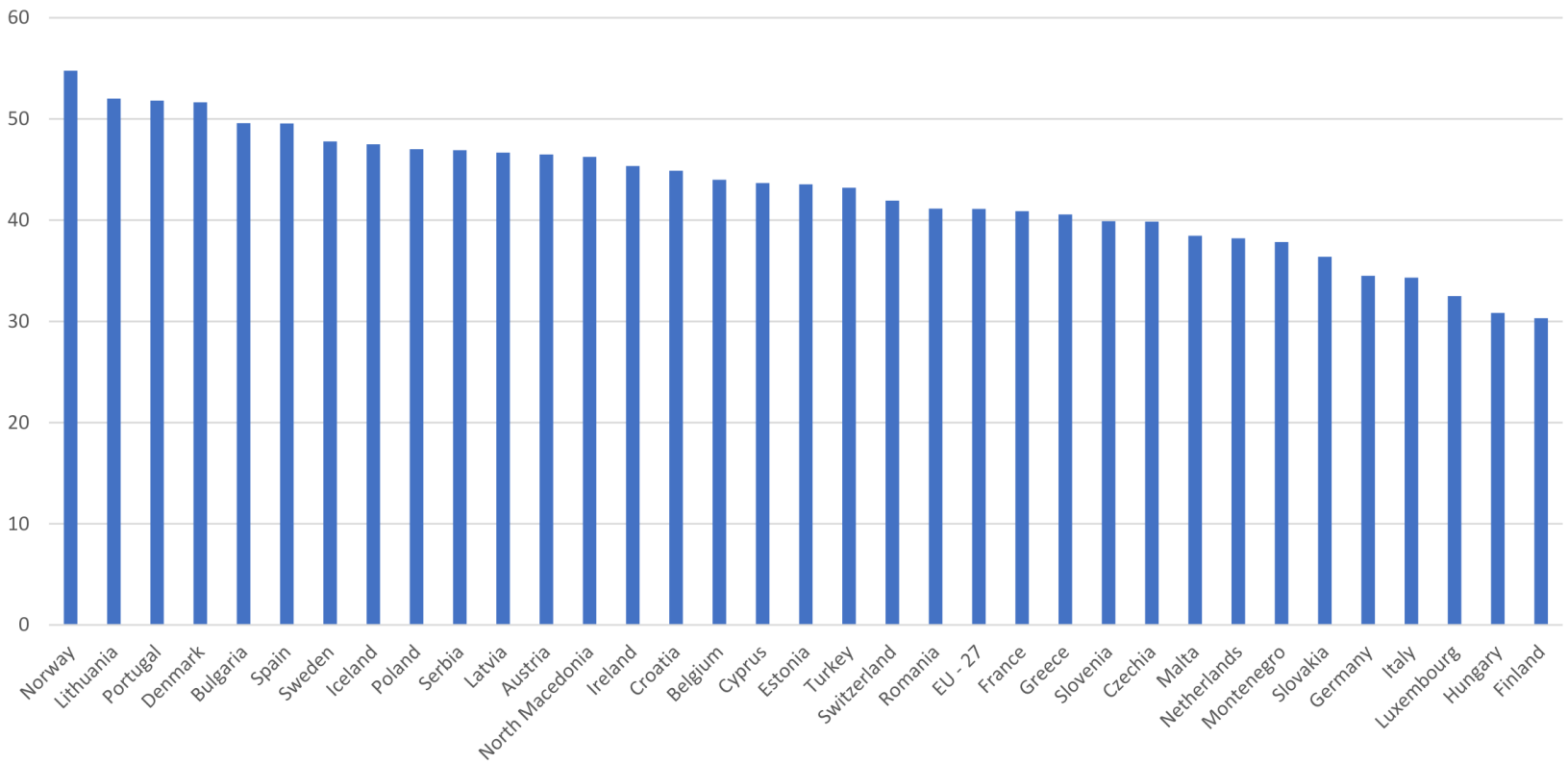


Source: UNESCO (via World Bank)

OurWorldInData.org/primary-and-secondary-education • CC BY

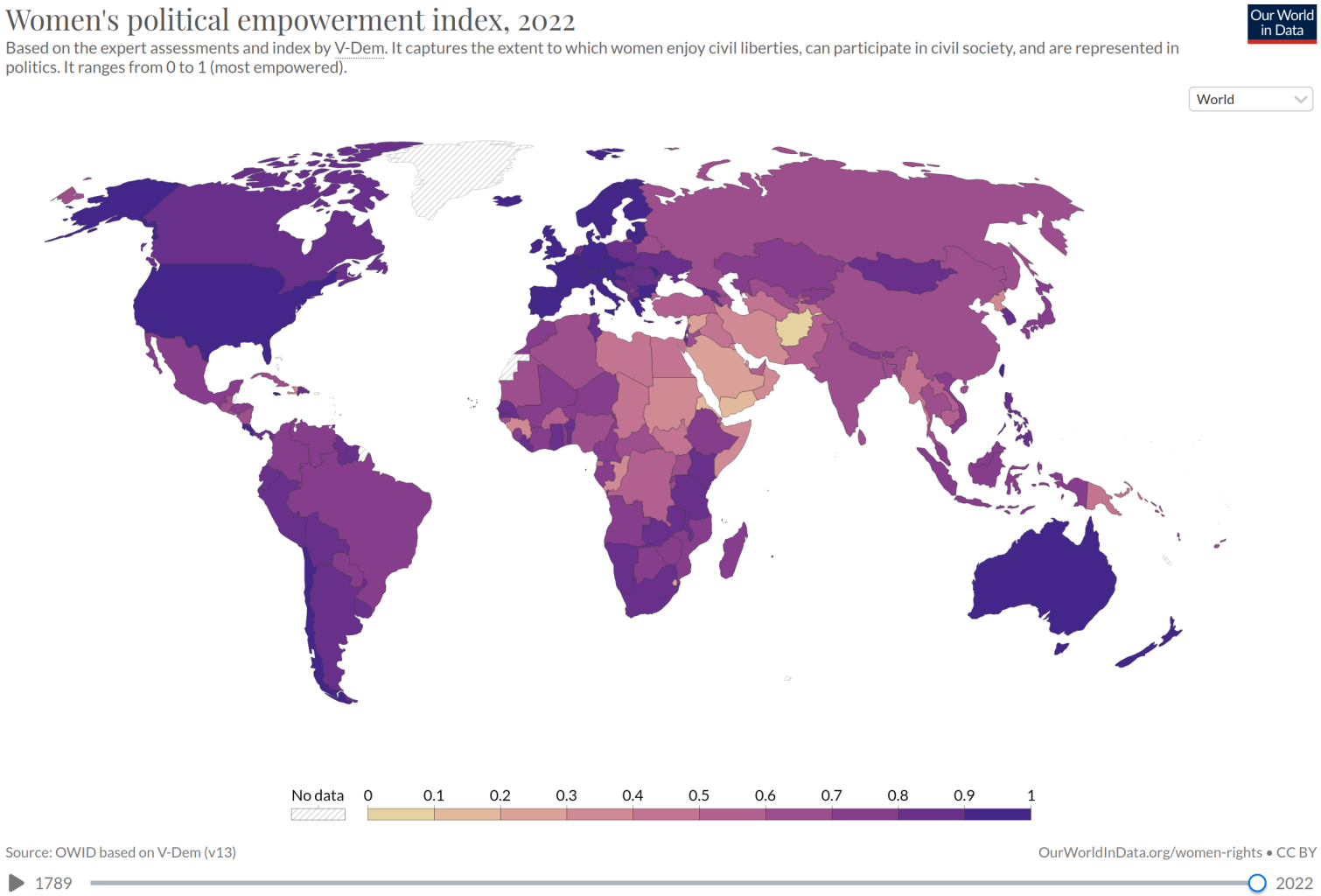
1986 2019

Share of women among scientists and engineers in Europe



Source: Eurostat, 2020

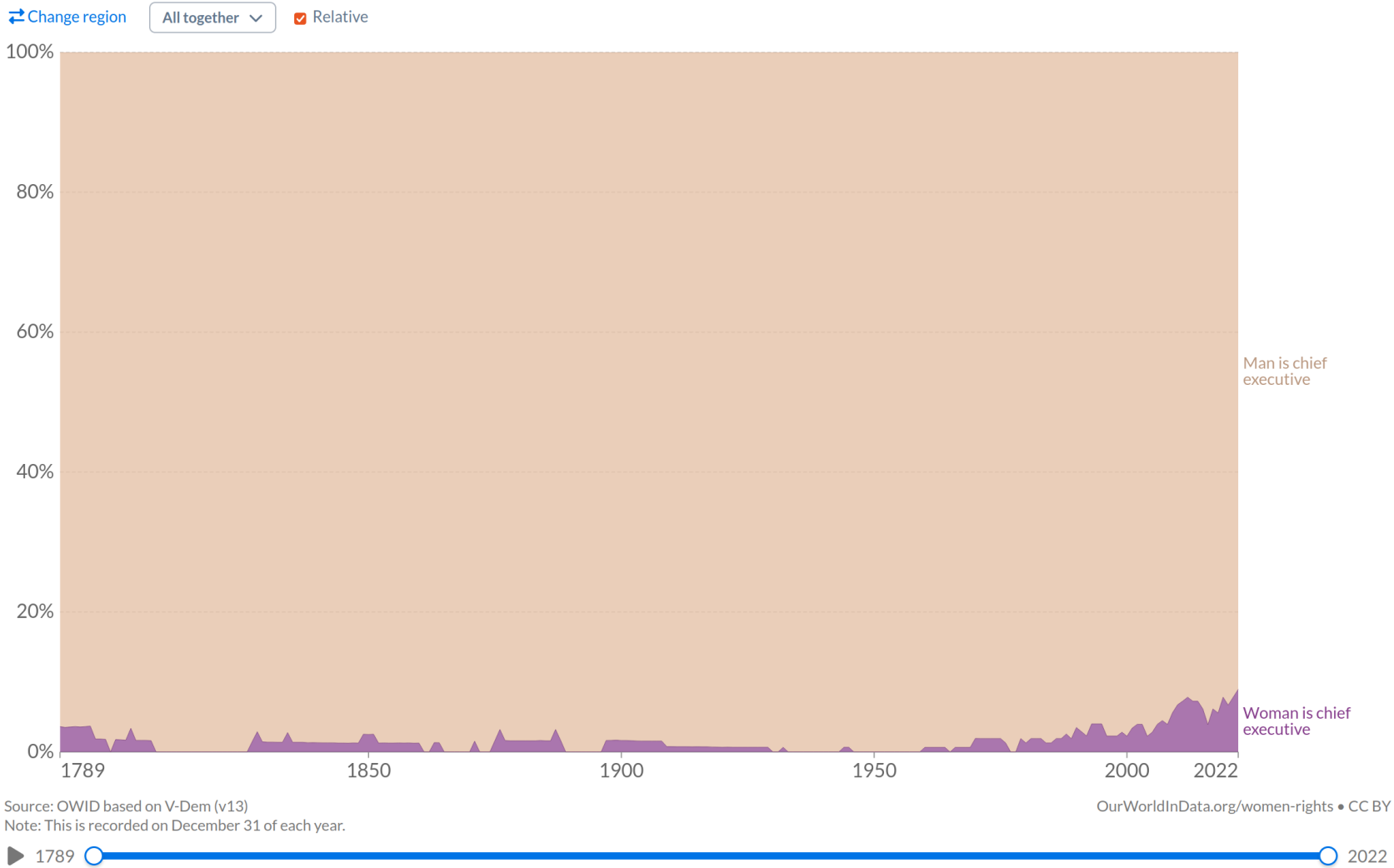
However, the underrepresentation of women in STEM-related studies and jobs remains a pressing issue.



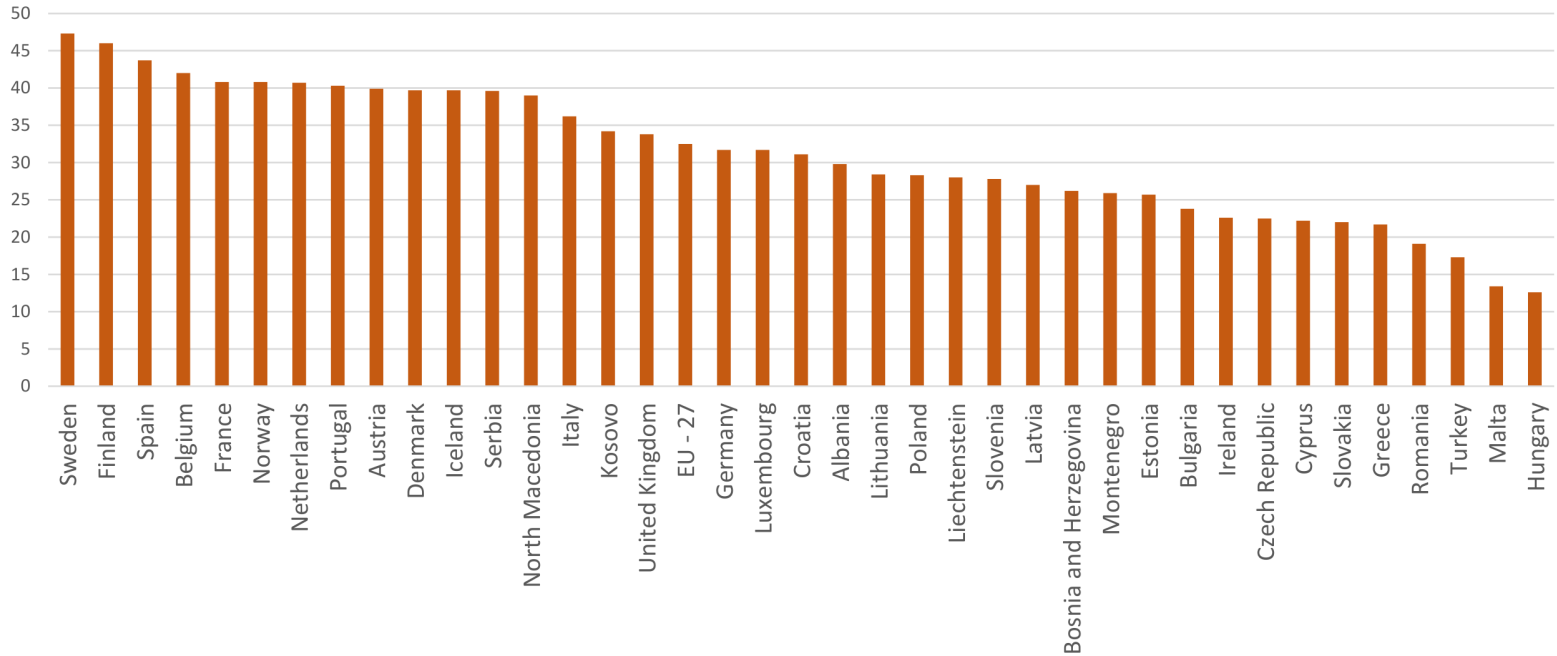
The political representation gap is also still wide and problematic [link].

Countries in which a woman is government's chief executive, World, 1789 to 2022

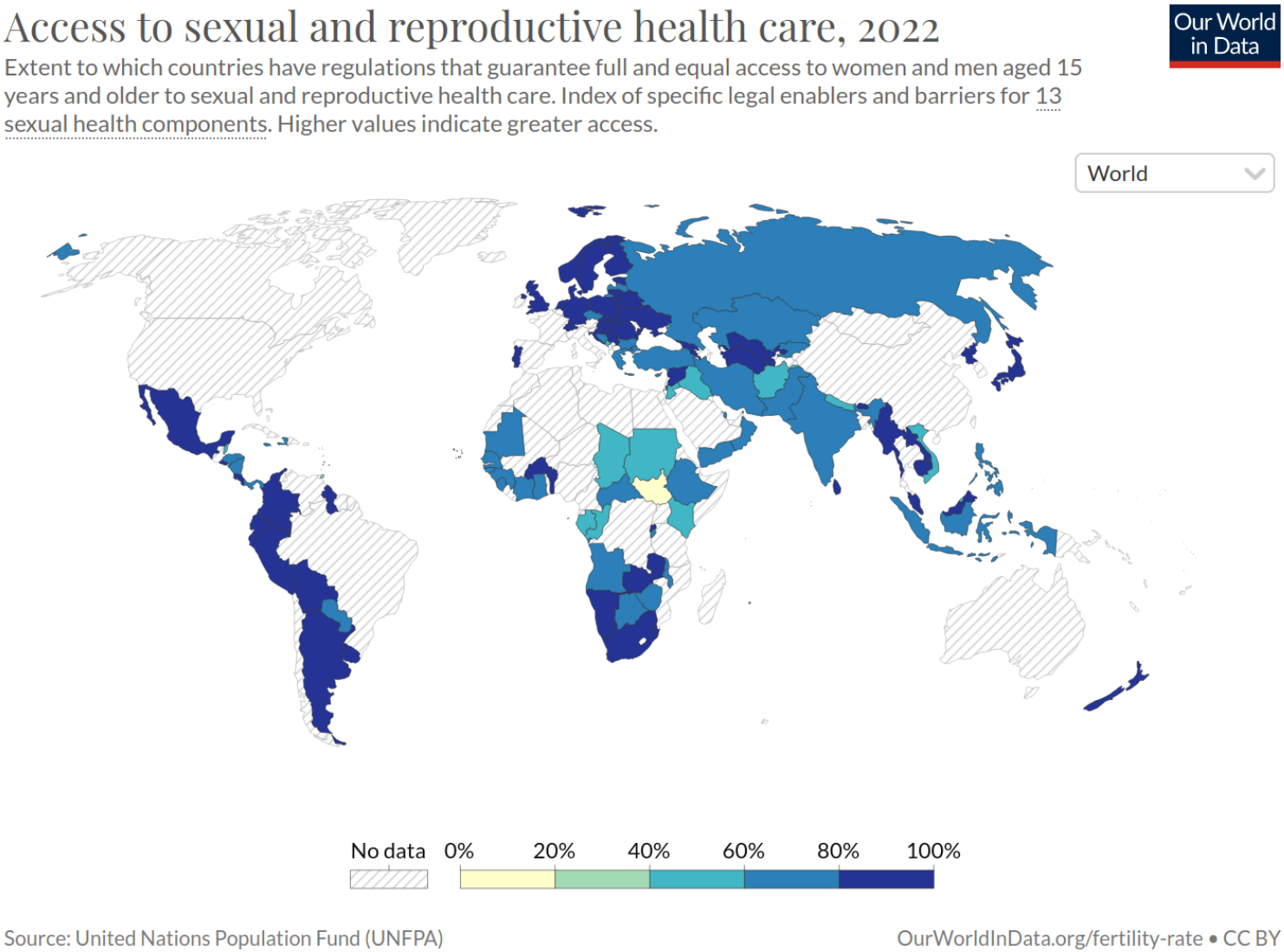
Chief executive is head of government or head of state, whoever has more power. This is recorded on December 31 of each year.



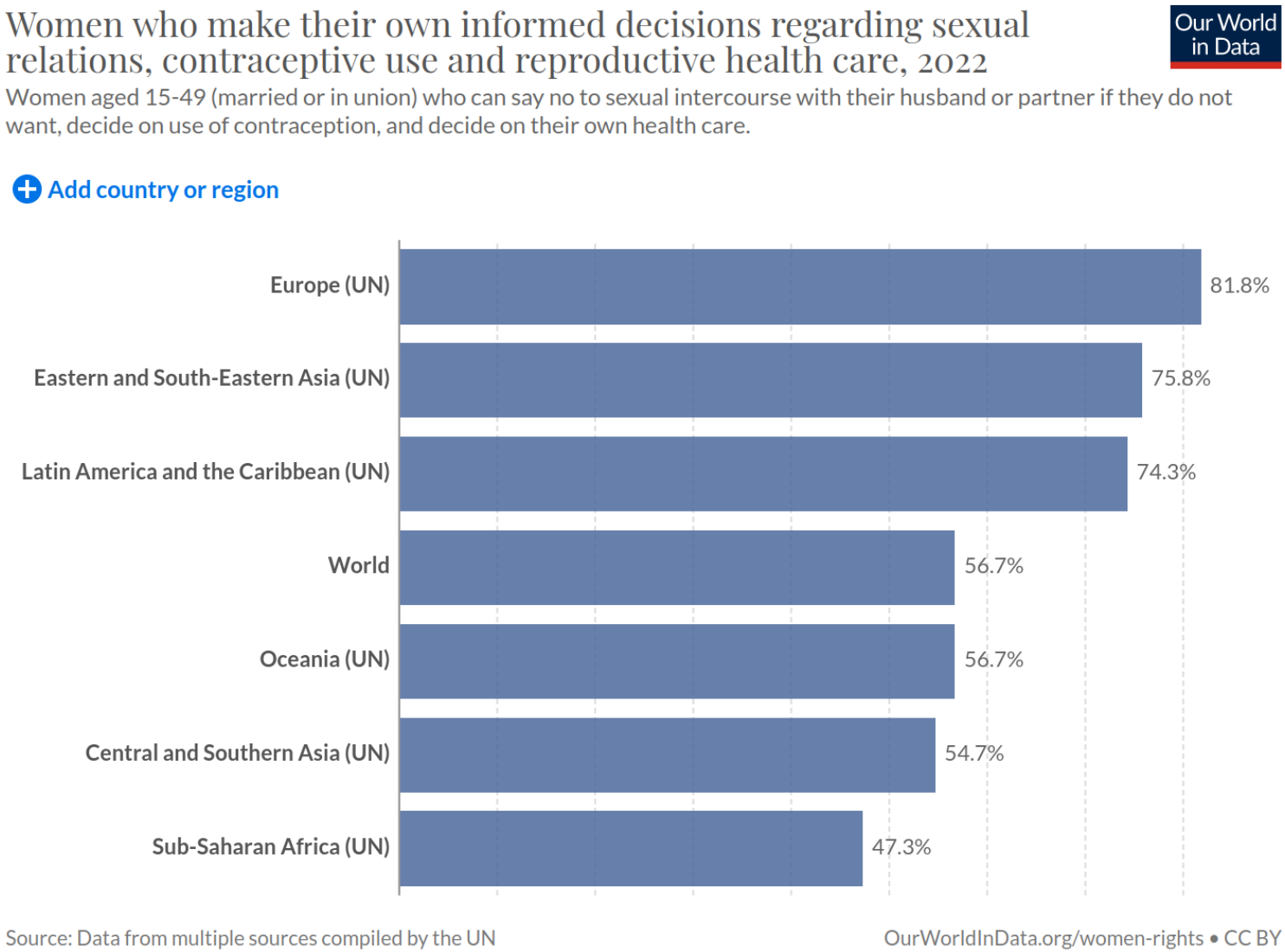
Share of women among Members of European National Parliaments



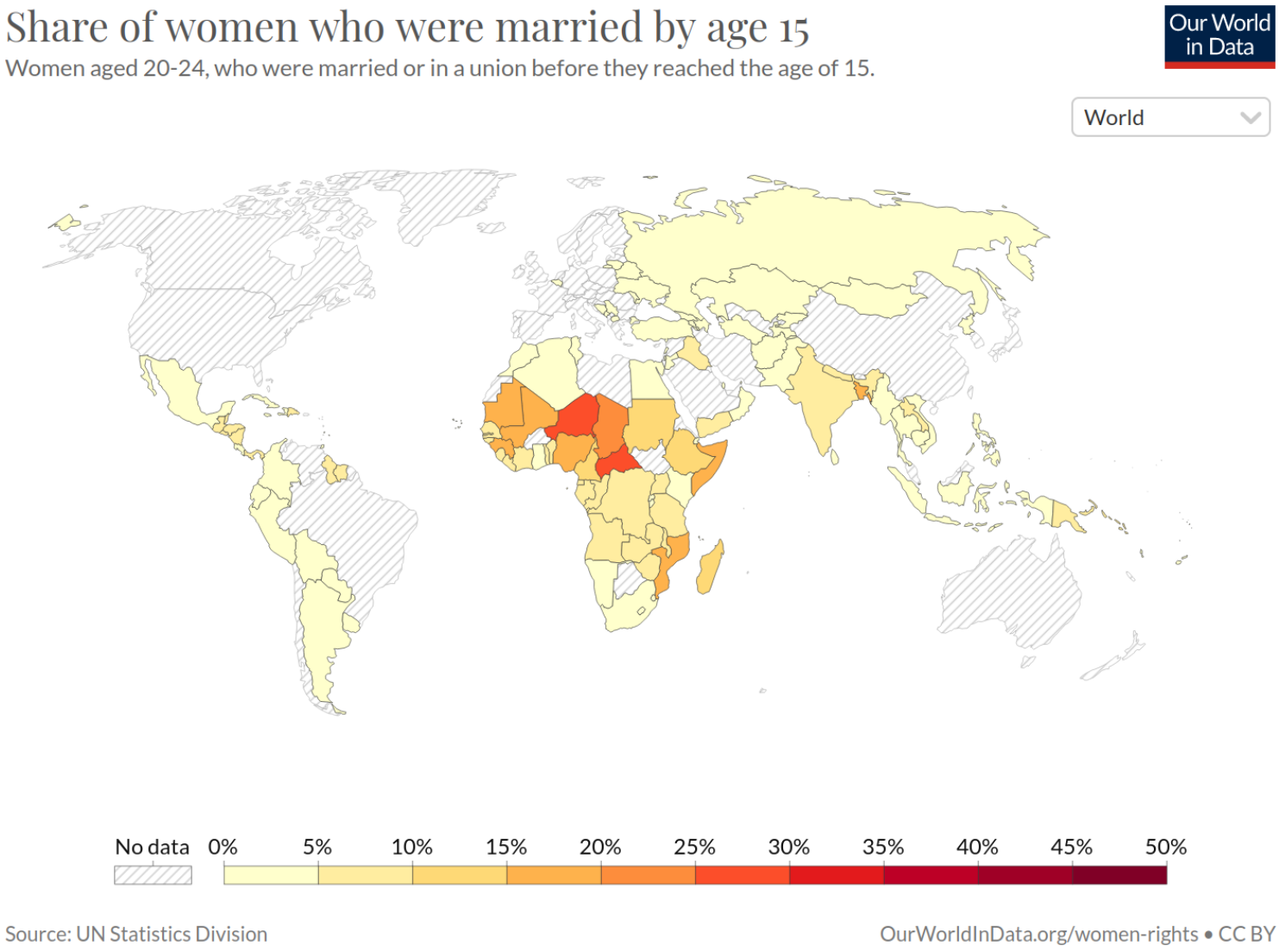
Source: EIGE, 2021



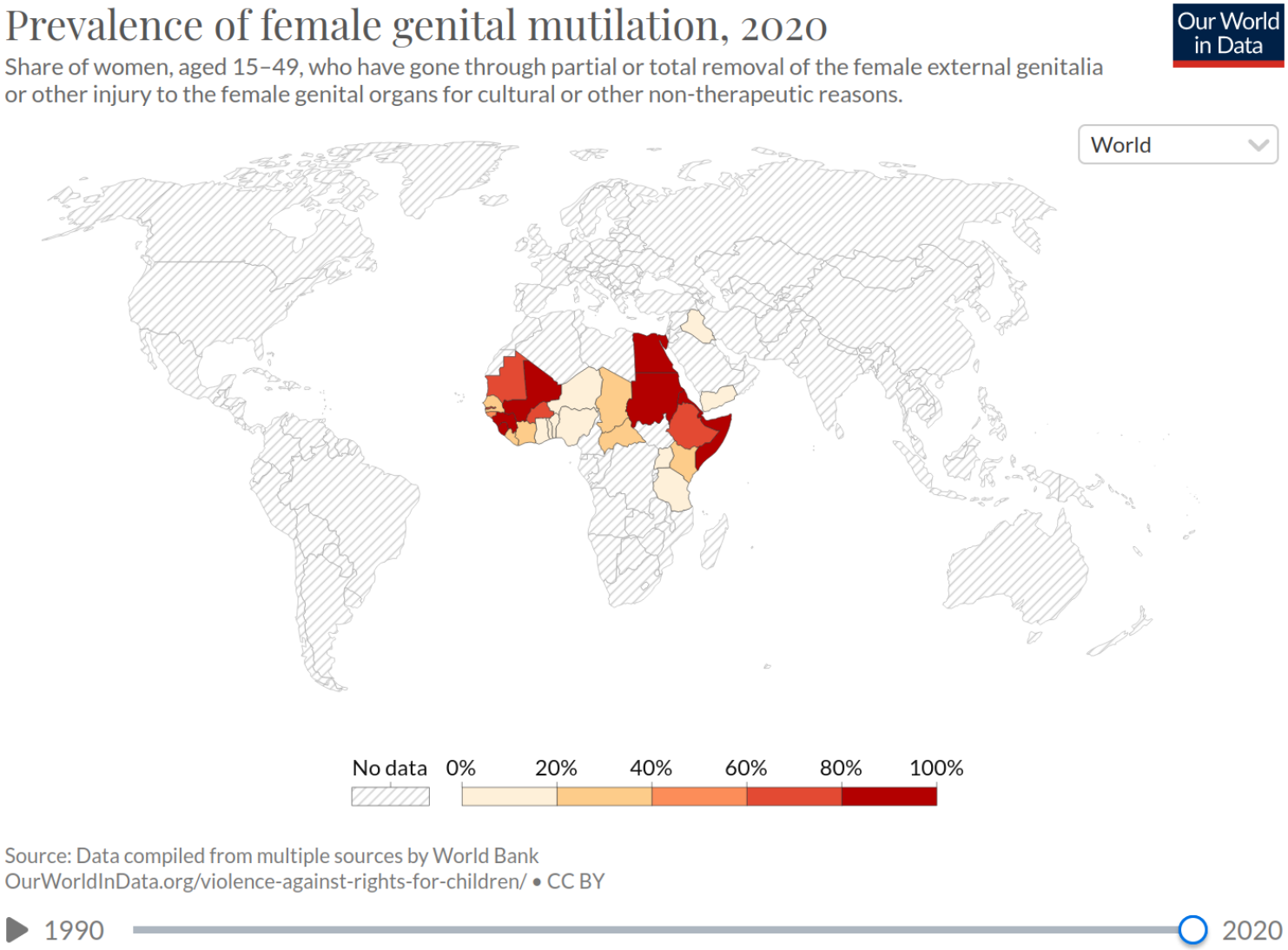
Access to healthcare is also unevenly distributed between genders (OWID, 2023).



Many women do not decide for their own bodies, as legal and informal norms constrain them.



An extreme case concerns forced marriages worldwide.



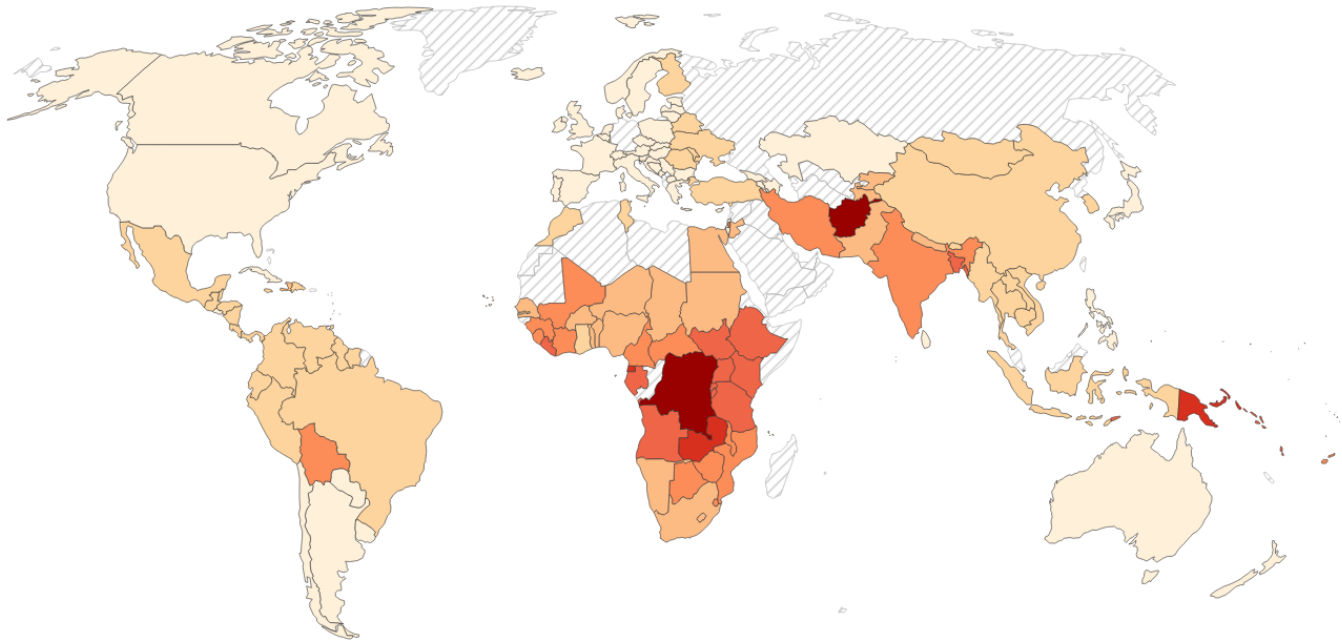
This inequality extends to extreme forms of violence.

Share of women who experienced violence from an intimate partner, 2018

Our World in Data

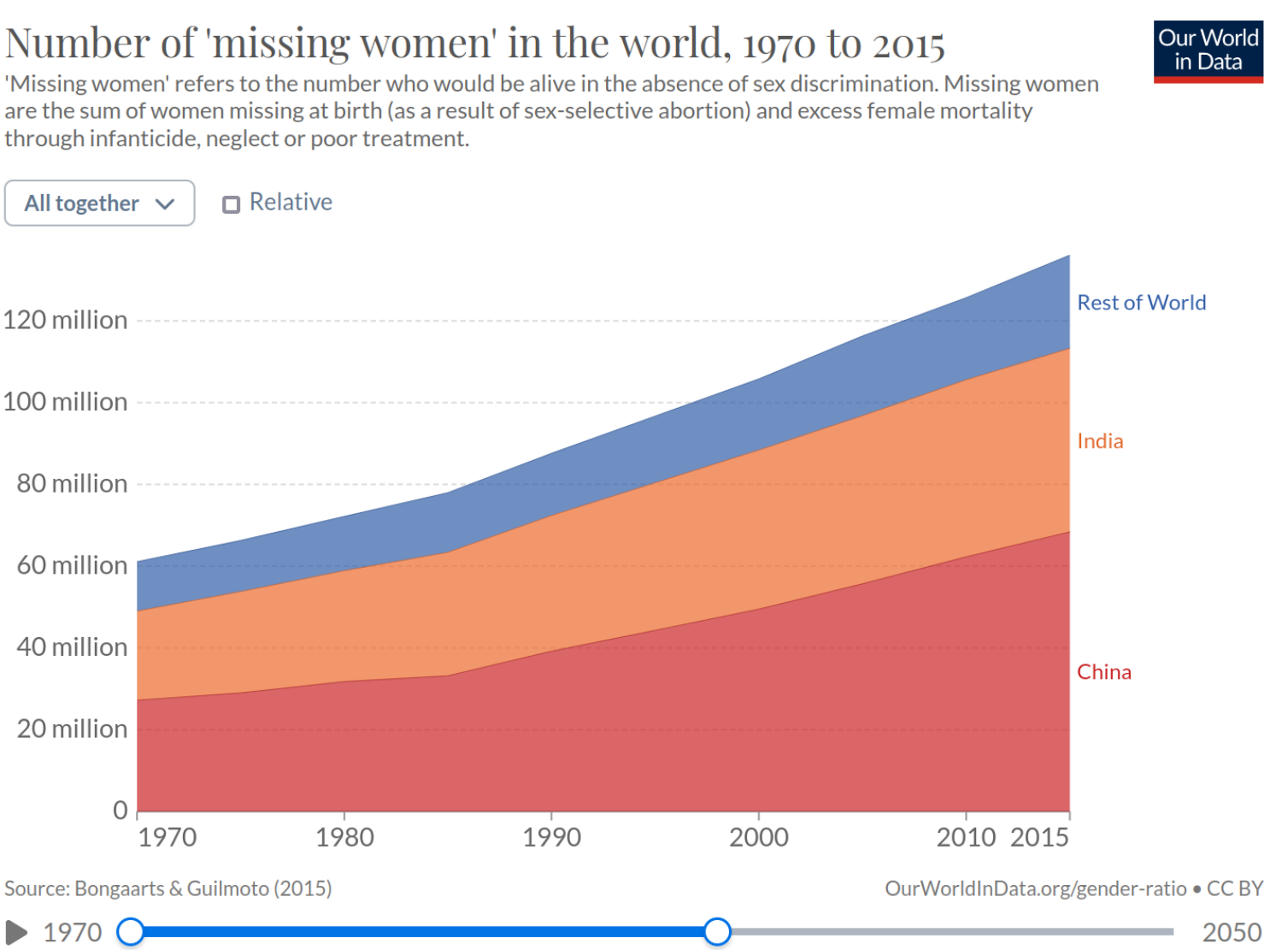
Women aged 15 and older who experienced physical or sexual violence from an intimate partner in the past year.

World



Source: Data from multiple sources compiled by the UN

OurWorldInData.org/women-rights • CC BY



Son preference is particularly worrisome in the developing world and creates major demographic imbalances (Ritchie and Roser, 2019).

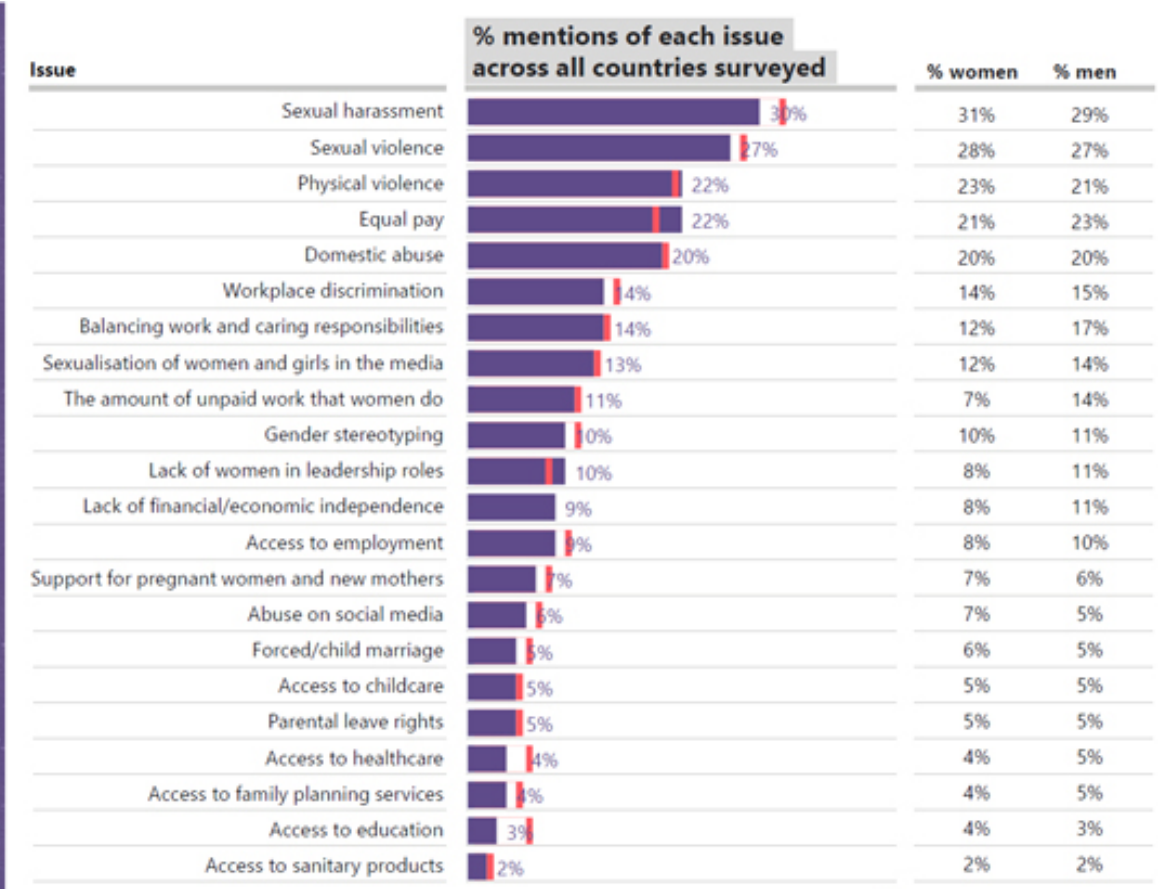
Ipsos

Q. Which two or three, if any of the following, do you think are the most important issues facing women and girls in (COUNTRY)?

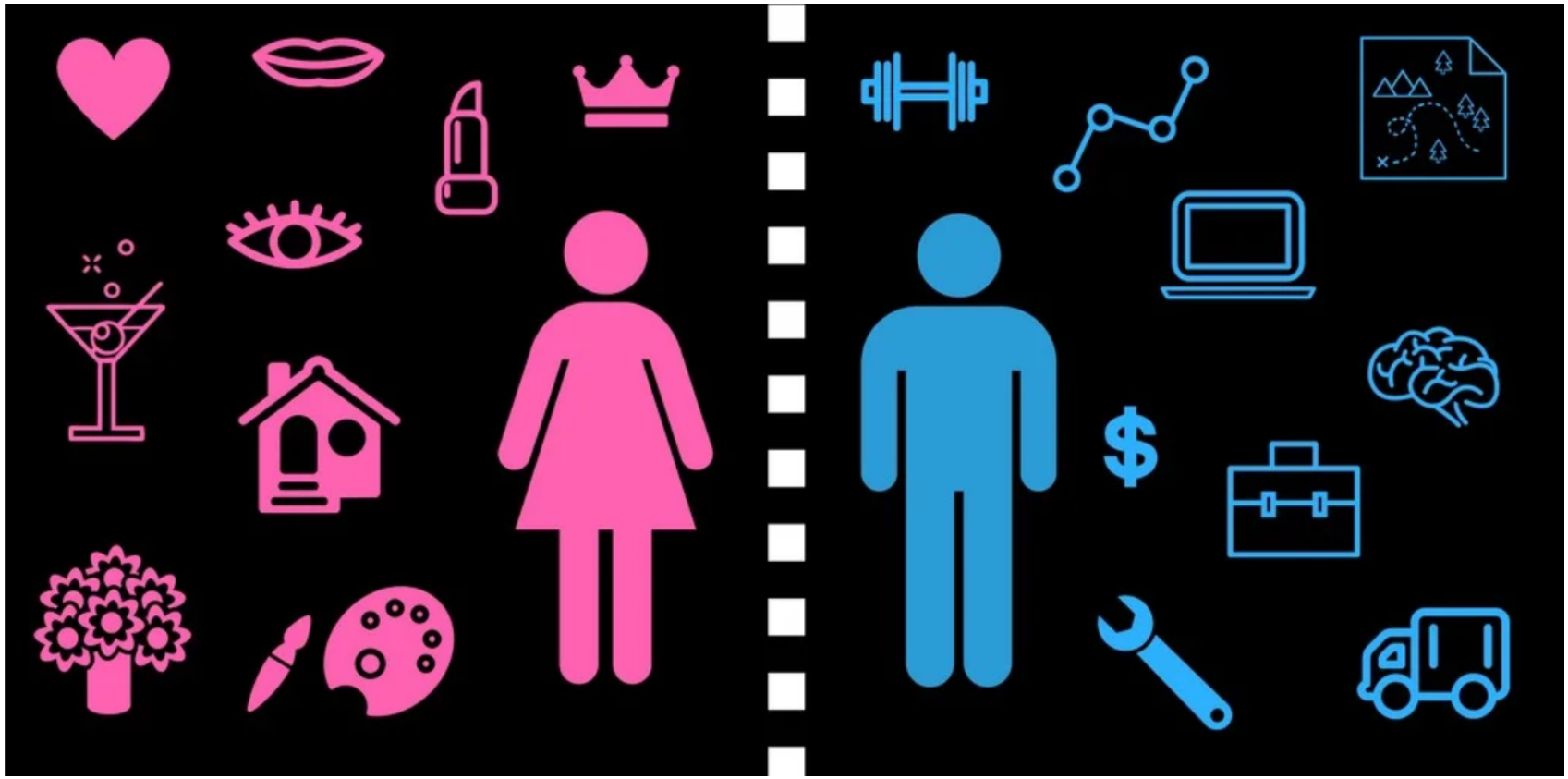
Globally, sexual harassment is seen as the most important issue facing women. This is followed by sexual violence, with around one in five picking out physical violence, domestic abuse and equal pay.

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Base: 18,800 online adults aged 16-64 across 27 countries, 21 Dec 2018 - 4 Jan 2019



Cultural values and stereotypes are a big chunk of the problem and the solution (overlooked for a long time by economists).

Ipsos

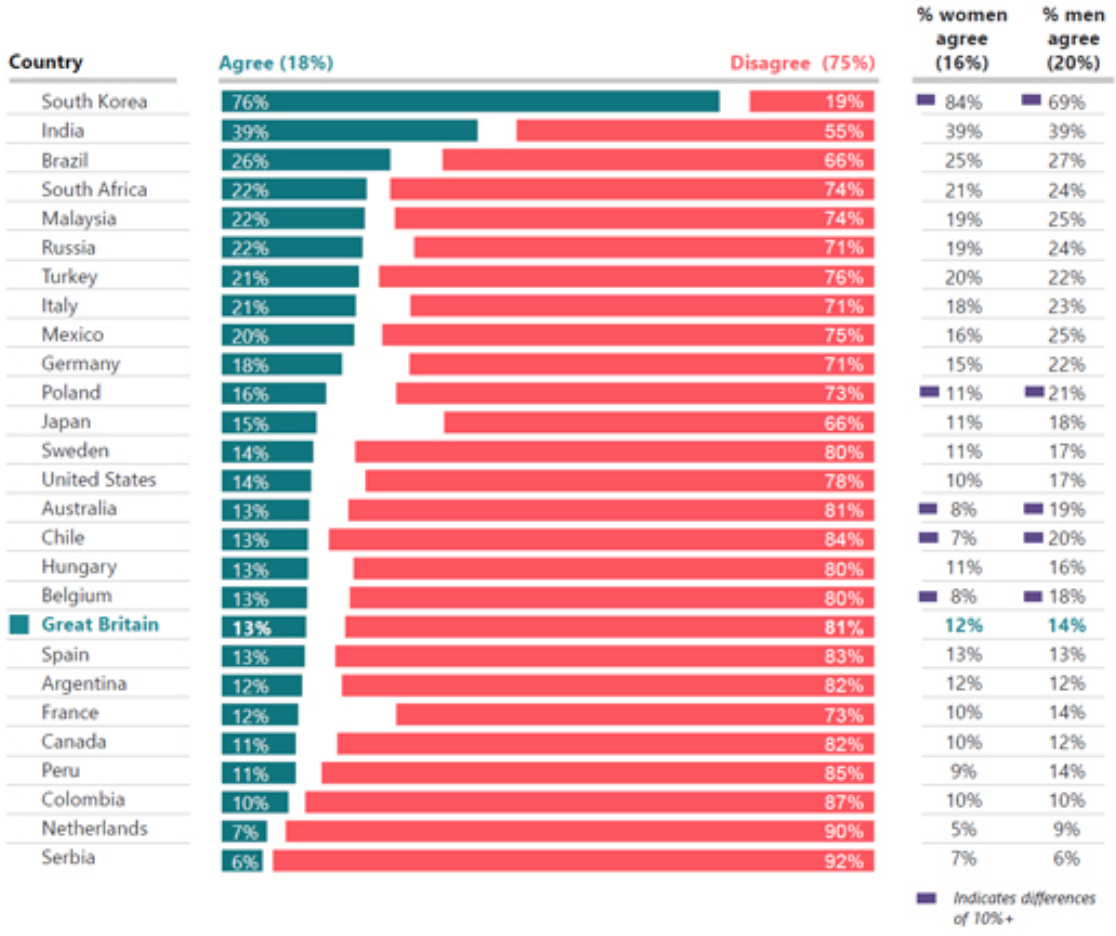
Q. Please indicate whether you strongly disagree, somewhat disagree, somewhat agree, or strongly agree that..

A man who stays home to look after his children is less of a man

The majority globally disagree that looking after children is emasculating for men – although less the case in South Korea

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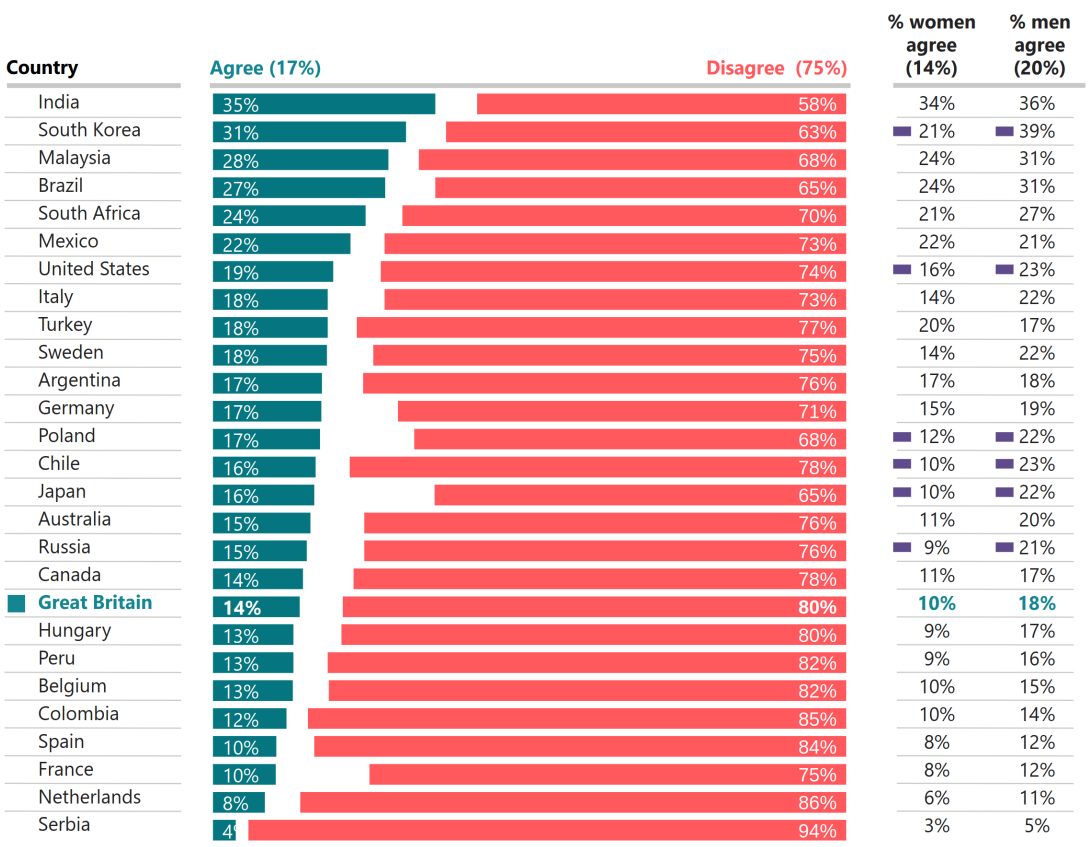
Q. Please indicate whether you strongly disagree, somewhat disagree, somewhat agree, or strongly agree that..

I'd feel uncomfortable if my boss was a woman

Three-quarters globally disagree they would feel uncomfortable with a female boss – but three in ten would in India, South Korea and Malaysia

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Base: 18,800 online adults aged 16-64 across 27 countries, 21 Dec 2018 - 4 Jan 2019

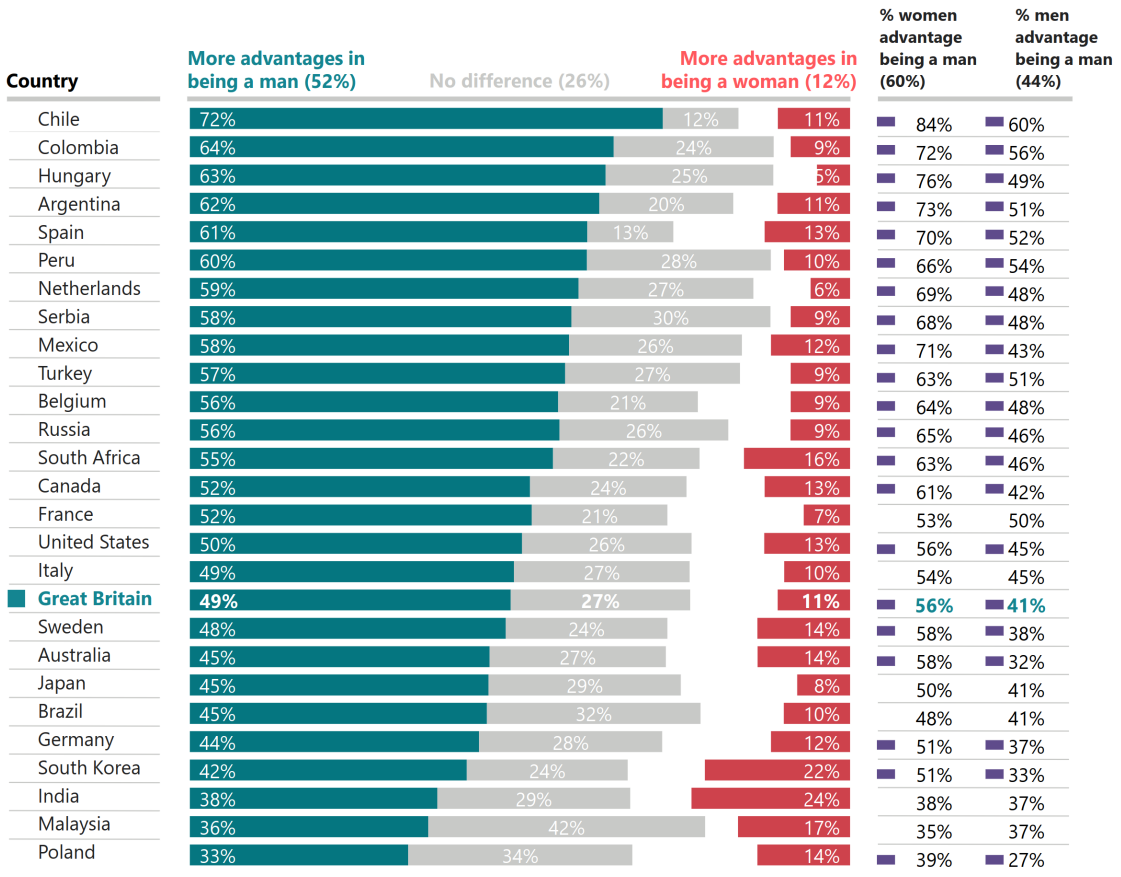
Ipsos

Q. All things considered, in our society today do you think that there are more advantages in being a man, or more advantages in being a woman, or is there no difference?

People in Chile, Colombia and Hungary most likely to believe there are more advantages to being a man today. On average only one in ten believe there are more advantages to being a woman

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Base: 18,800 online adults aged 16-64 across 27 countries, 21 Dec 2018 - 4 Jan 2019

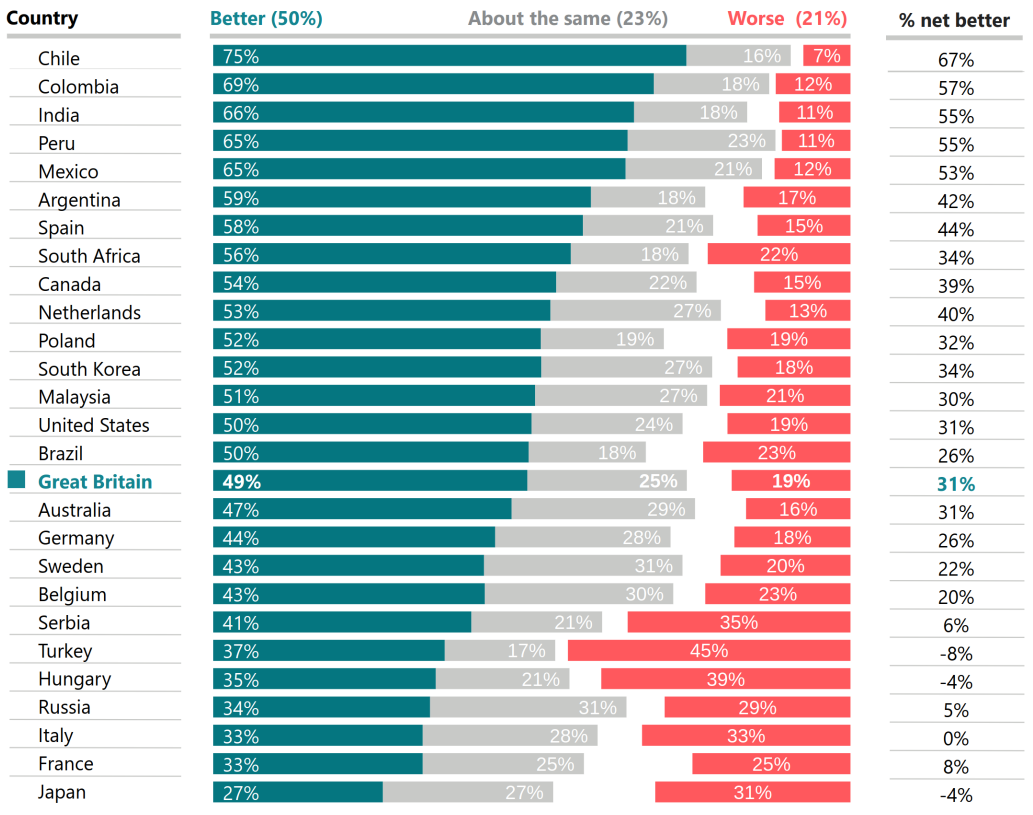
Ipsos

Q. To what extent, if at all, do you feel that young women today in [COUNTRY] will have had a better or worse life than women from their parents' generation, or will it have been the same?

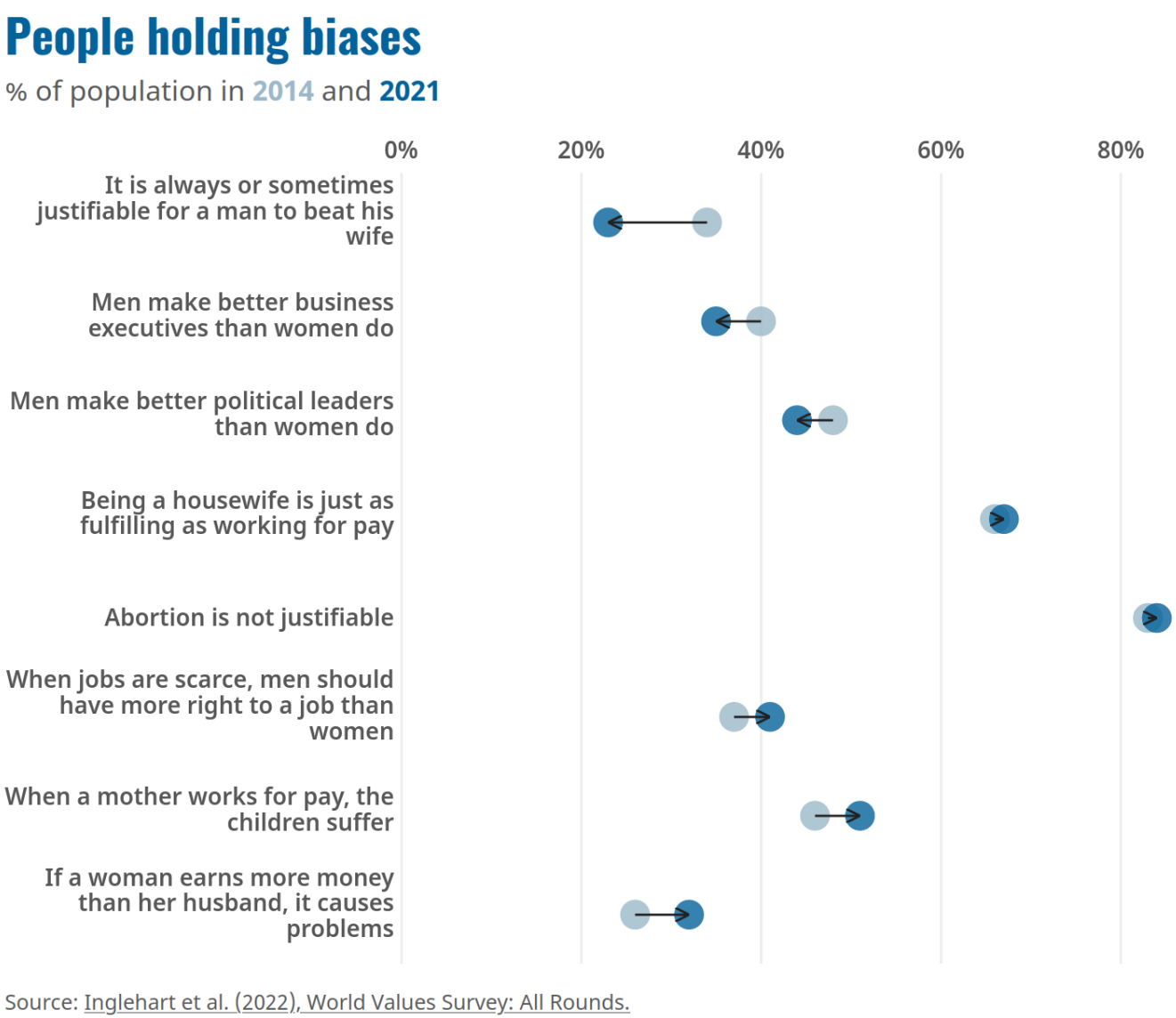
Half believe women today will have a better life than women of their parents' generation – highest in Chile, Columbia and India. But in Japan, Hungary and Turkey the balance of opinion is negative

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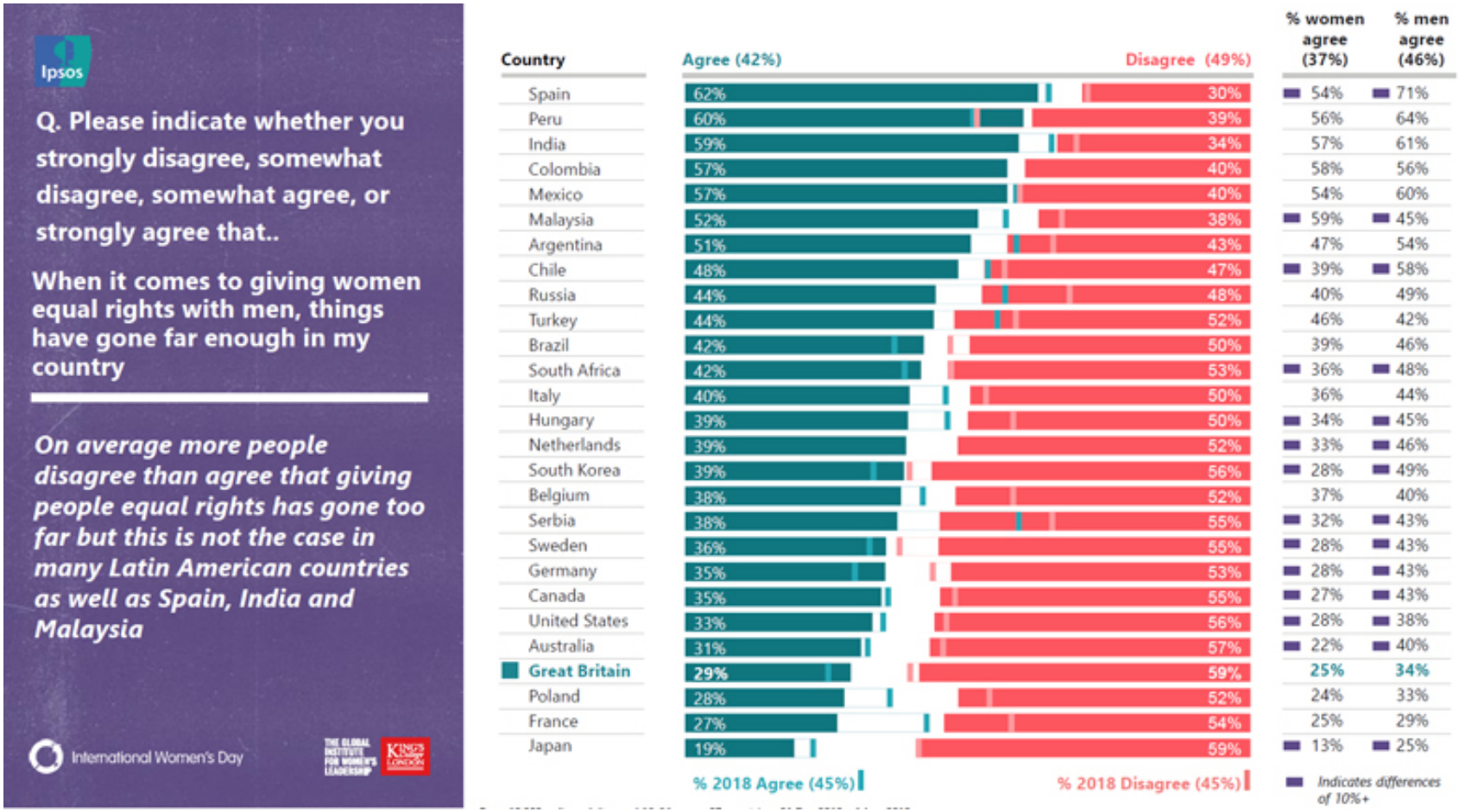
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Base: 18,800 online adults aged 16-64 across 27 countries, 21 Dec 2018 - 4 Jan 2019



To some extent, people are right to be hopeful for the future.



But there is still some push back from part of the population.

Ipsos

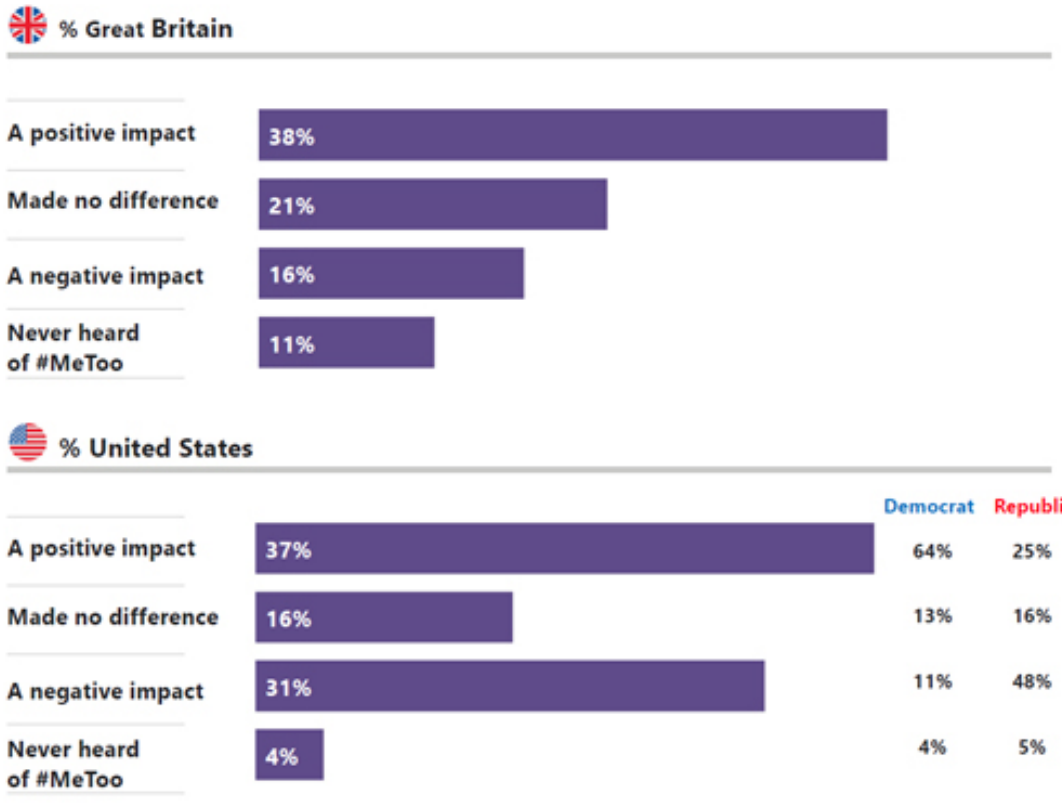
Q. As you may or may not know, the #MeToo movement is a campaign that encourages women to speak out about their experiences of sexual harassment and sexual assault. It became widespread in 2017 after allegations of sexual abuse against women by high profile men.

Now thinking about the #MeToo movement, do you think it has had a positive impact on society, a negative impact on society or has it made no difference?

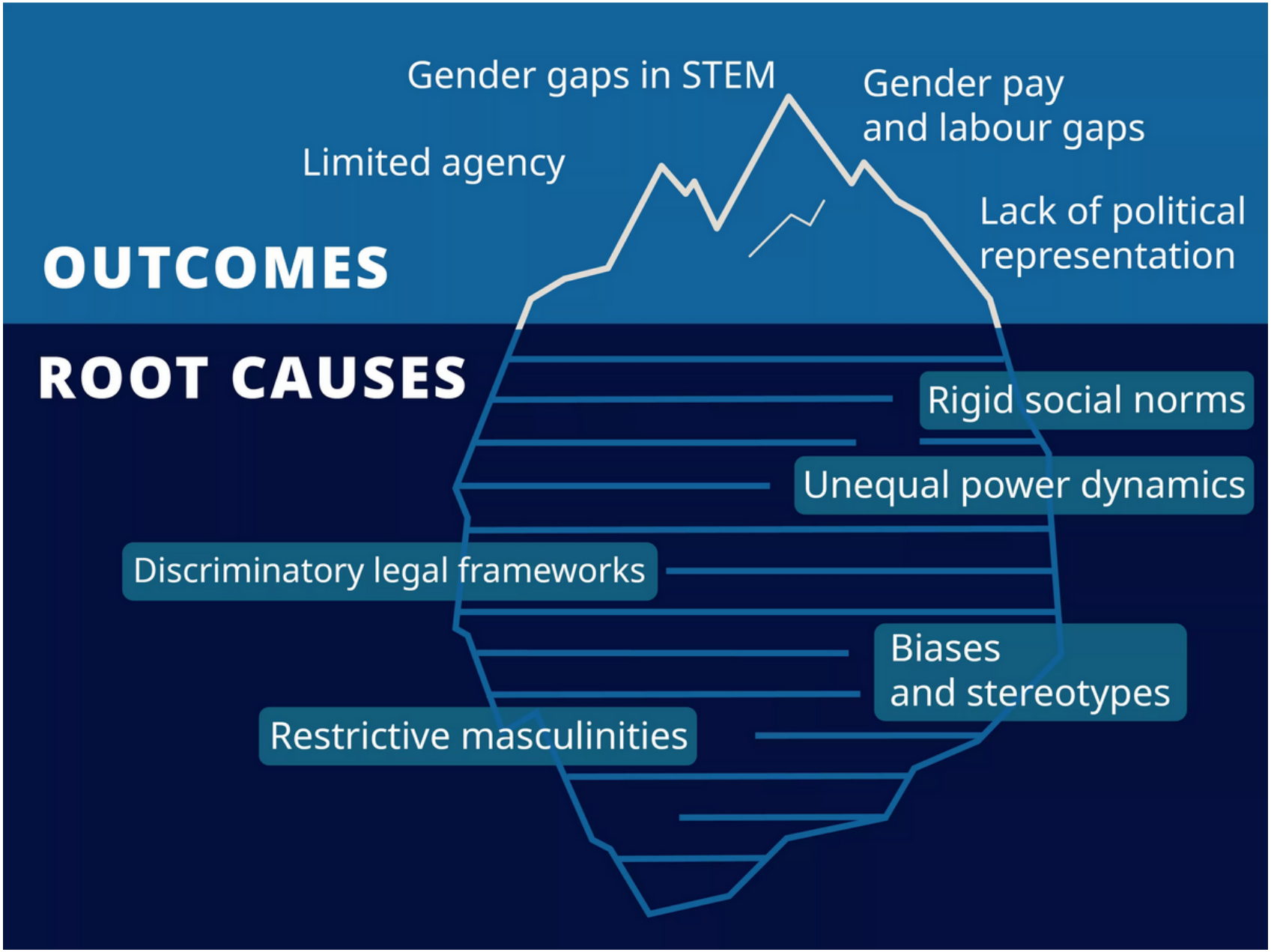
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Base: 2,002 online adults aged 16-64 across 2 countries, 21 Dec 2018 - 4 Jan 2019


Gender gaps in STEM
Gender pay
and labour gaps
Limited agency
Lack of political
representation
OUTCOMES
ROOT CAUSES
Rigid social norms
Unequal power dynamics
Discriminatory legal frameworks
Biases
and stereotypes
Restrictive masculinities

What's next?

In the next lectures, we will dig deeper into measurement tools for inequalities that go beyond raw empirical evidence.

We will focus on the United States for data and research quality reasons.

Given the country's history of slavery, we will also have the opportunity to discuss racial gaps.

Ortiz-Ospina, E. and Roser, M. (2018). Economic inequality by gender. *Our World in Data*. https://ourworldindata.org/economic-inequality-by-gender.

OWID (2023). Achieve gender equality and empower all women and girls. *Our World in Data*. https://ourworldindata.org/sdgs/gender-equality.

Ritchie, H. and Roser, M. (2019). Gender ratio. *Our World in Data*. https://ourworldindata.org/gender-ratio.

WEF (2022). Global gender gap report. *World Economic Forum*. https://www.weforum.org/reports/global-gender-gap-report-2022/.